



IT'S FUN TO SEW

with a sewing machine

COOPERATIVE EXTENSION SERVICE
OREGON STATE UNIVERSITY, CORVALLIS

PHASE 1
4-H CLUB SERIES L-85



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The Project Gutenberg eBook of It's Fun to Sew with a Sewing Machine

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK IT'S FUN TO
SEW WITH A SEWING MACHINE ***

IT'S FUN TO SEW with a sewing machine

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It's Fun to Sew—With the Sewing Machine

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PHASE 1

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Read this book from cover to cover before you start your project.

Your guide for the project

What you will learn

1. The names and use of common sewing tools.
2. To organize a sewing box.
3. To develop good sewing habits.
4. To combine pretty colors.
5. To use the sewing machine.

What articles you will make

As a club member, you will be required to complete two articles.

First you will make *one* practice article:

A case for your sewing shears.

Then you will make *one* main project article:

A barbecue placemat or a traveling kit.

Start your record book

Attend all your meetings so that you will be able to complete your project as soon as possible. When your home agent gives you a 4-H record book and record sheets, she wants you to record the work you do on your project. Give her this information in writing. Tell her how much you enjoyed making the articles and how much you and your family enjoyed using them.

Learn to give a demonstration

Show others what “tricks” you have learned by giving a demonstration at one of your club meetings, or ask your mother to invite your family friends to your home. It will be fun to use the placemats or show them your other projects. They will be interested in how they were made. Tell them what you did and what you learned about using your mother’s sewing machine and the sewing tools.

Plan your project

Your projects will be more interesting if you plan them with your mother and leader, because they can help you to understand and enjoy your new adventures in sewing. Take your mother with you to your first meeting to introduce her to your leader and your friends. This will also give her an opportunity to see the kind of projects you will be working on during this year.

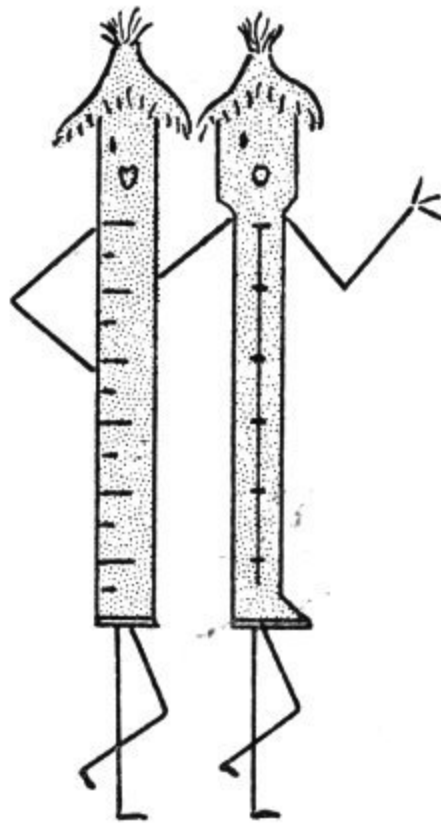
You will need your mother's cooperation and advice in selecting both equipment and fabrics for the projects. She may be able to loan you some of her sewing tools too. Sharing with your mother as you work will help you learn to know each other better.

Before shopping for your supplies, read your bulletin to see what supplies are needed. Plan ahead so you can do all your shopping for your articles at one time.

It is not necessary for the colors of the fabrics used in these projects to match or even blend, because they are not going to be used together. But—since the articles may be exhibited together, they will look nicer if the colors look pretty when placed next to each other.

Become acquainted with your sewing tools

Measuring tools



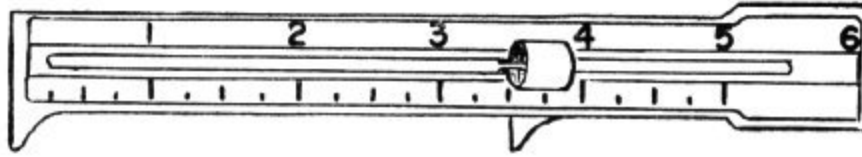
Measuring gauge (6 inches)

Ruler (12 inches)

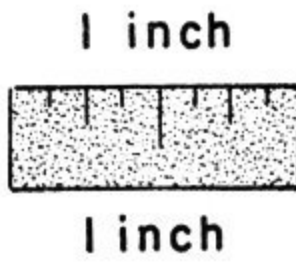
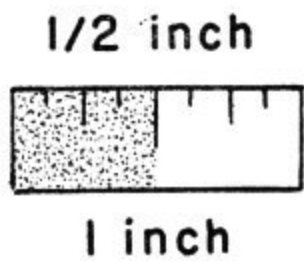
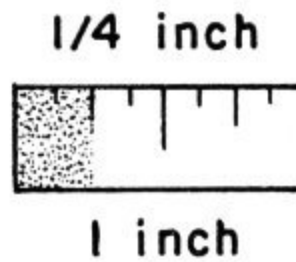
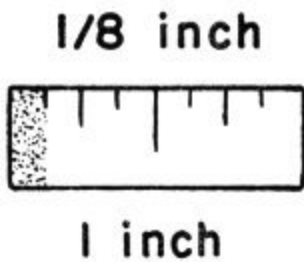
Yardstick (36 inches or 1 yard)

Measuring Tape (60 inches)

Measuring tools are each marked with many short lines to help you measure fractions of an inch or inches.

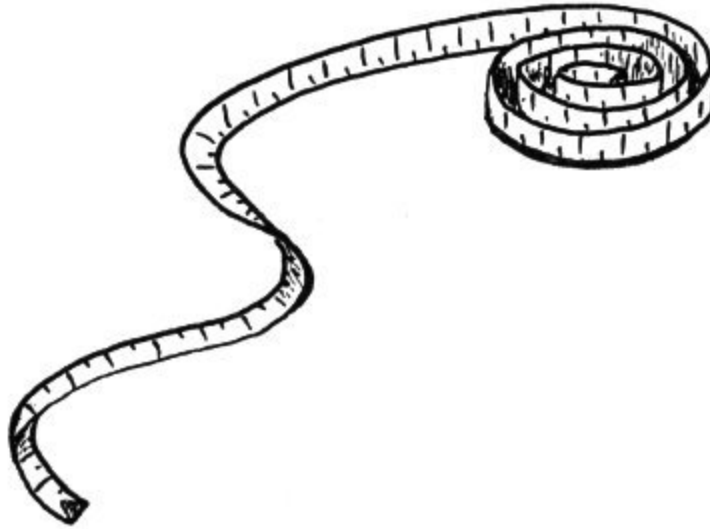


You will want to use the measuring gauge or the ruler for measuring short distances.



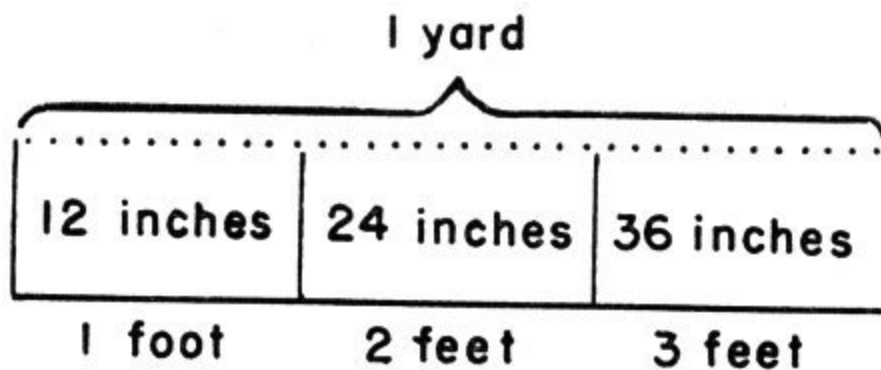
- 1/8 inch
- 1/4 inch
- 1/2 inch
- 1 inch

If you want to measure anything longer than 12 inches, you will need to use either the measuring tape or the yardstick.



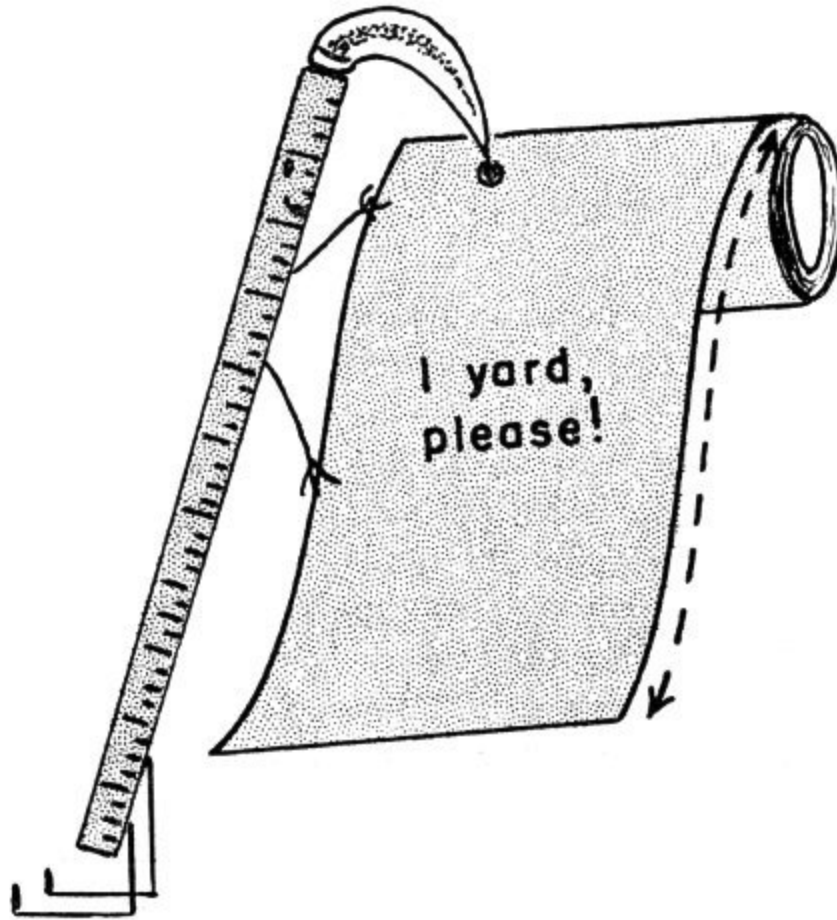
A measuring tape will help you measure inches or feet.

12 inches—1 foot
 24 inches—2 feet
 36 inches—3 feet
 48 inches—4 feet
 60 inches—5 feet



The yardstick will measure inches, feet, or yards for you.

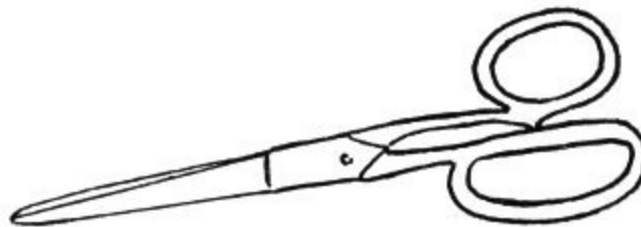
1 yard		
12 inches	24 inches	36 inches
1 foot	2 feet	3 feet



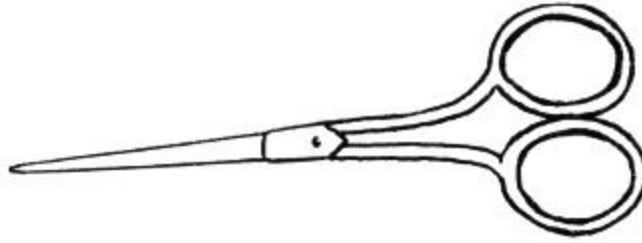
Material is sold by the yard or fraction of yard.

Cutting tools

3



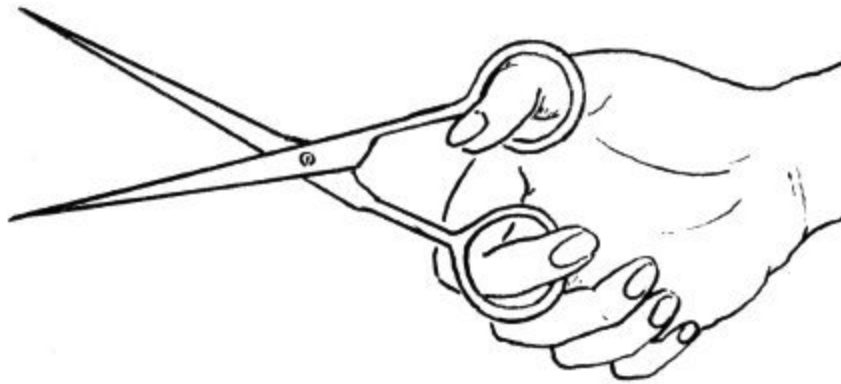
Pair of Shears



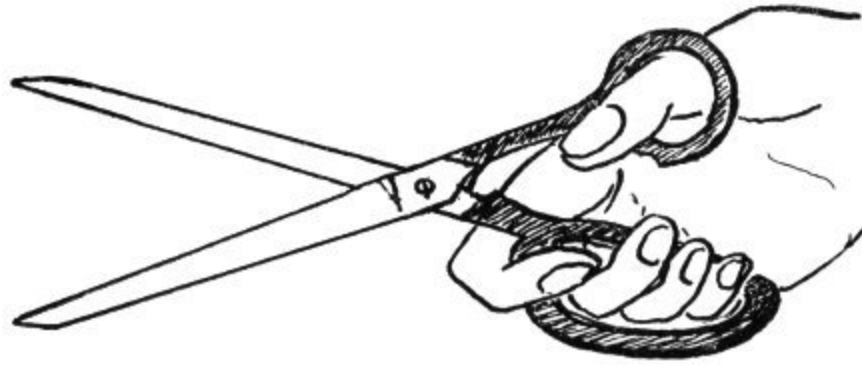
Pair of Scissors

If your mother has several types of cutting tools in her sewing box, you have already learned that shears and scissors will cut both fabric and thread, but one is easier to use for cutting thread than the other.

Little scissors like the small pair illustrated are meant to clip thread or cut narrow things like ribbon, elastic, etc. Scissors have very sharp and narrow points to make it possible to clip into tiny corners. Scissors have two handles the same size.



When you cut with scissors, put your thumb through one handle and a finger through the other. A pair of small scissors about 4 inches in length is easy to handle.



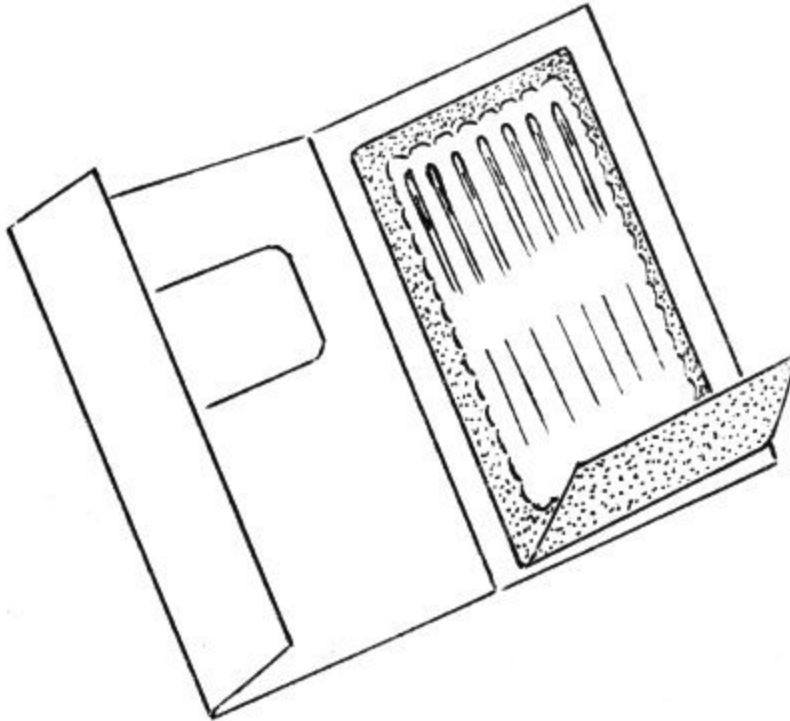
Shears are larger than scissors, and they are used for cutting a pattern out of material. Shears have one large handle and one small one. When you cut with shears, place your thumb through the small handle and two or three fingers through the larger handle. A pair of 7-inch shears is a good size for you.

Sewing tools



Needles and Pins and Pincushion and Thimble

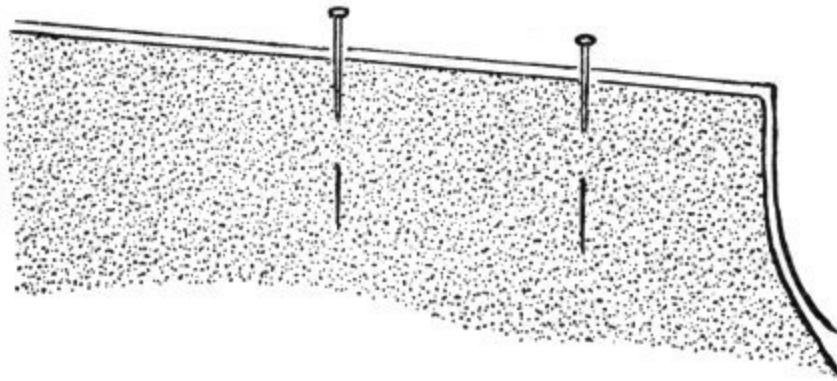
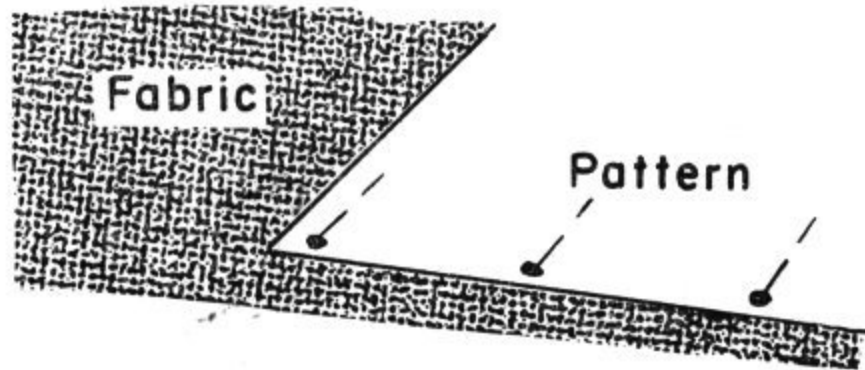
Needles



When you buy needles, search for slender ones with long eyes. If they are slender, they will slip in and out of the material without much effort. The long eye will be easier for you to thread. Also notice the length of the needles. Will they be easy for you to handle? 4

Pins

Pins are used to hold the pattern and material together while you cut out a pattern, or to help you hold the pieces of material together when you are getting ready to sew.

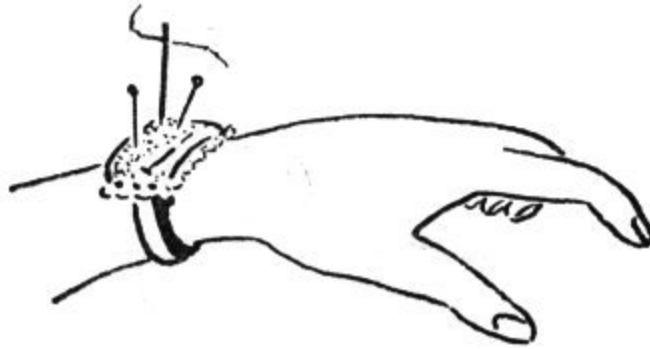


If you borrow some pins from your mother, you will be a smart little girl if you notice whether they *slip* into your material easily. Avoid using pins that are too large or have a blunt point. They are likely to snag or tear the material.

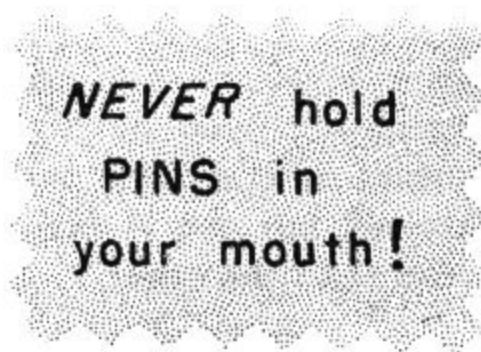
If you buy new pins, ask the saleslady for *brass pins*. These are strong pins, but fine in size.

Pincushion

To help you develop the habit of putting pins and needles into a pincushion, always remember to wear your pincushion when you sew. If you drop pins or needles they are hard to find because they are small and will easily slip into a hiding place, where they may hurt someone later.



The wrist pincushion is the most convenient. If you are right-handed, wear the pincushion near your wrist on your left arm. If you are left-handed, wear the pincushion near your wrist on your right arm.



Thimble

People who sew usually wear thimbles for several reasons. They help to push the needle through the material, and they protect the finger from being

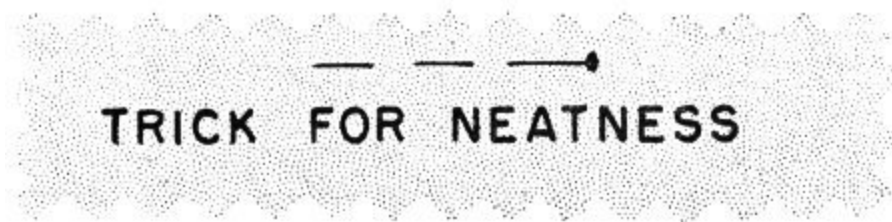
pricked by the needle.

To push the needle through the material with the end of the thimble, hold the needle between the thumb and the first finger so that the eye end of the needle is resting against the end of the thimble.



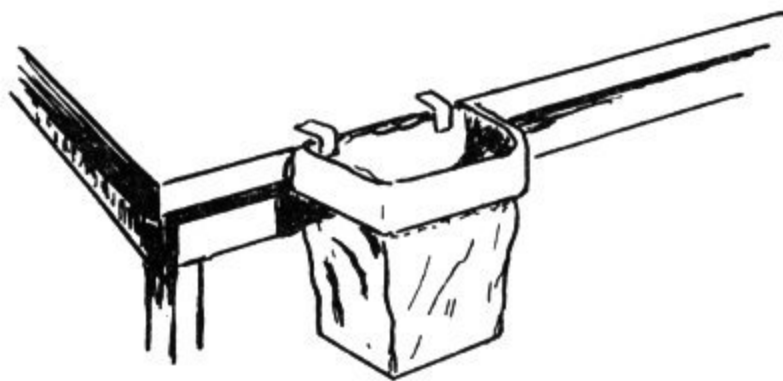
Buy the size that fits your middle finger snugly.

5



TRICK FOR NEATNESS

When you begin to use the sewing machine, you will be snipping many threads. Keep the area around your sewing table neat by using a paper bag for a wastebasket for scraps of material, paper, and thread. Fasten it to the edge of the table where you can reach it easily when you are sitting at the machine.



Organize a box or basket for tools and supplies

All of your sewing tools are like a happy family—each has a job to do to help you sew. You will therefore, find it helpful to know where your tools are and to keep them in place when you are not using them, instead of leaving your thimble on the arm of a chair, the shears hidden under a newspaper, or a bobbin in your pocket.

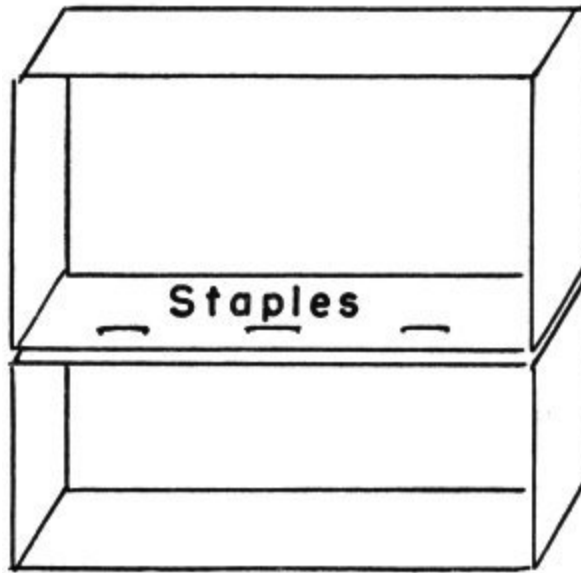
A box is easy to organize into an equipment box and convenient to store in your dresser drawer, on your closet shelf, or in a bigger box which will hold your projects.

You should look for two kinds of boxes—one large box and many small ones. The large box should be sturdy, clean, and long enough to hold your longest tool. The pincushion may become the tallest tool when it is covered with pins and needles.

The small boxes may vary in size. Tiny boxes like those used for earrings are good for small items like the thimble, bobbins, etc. Bigger boxes are needed for the pincushion, thread, and other items.

When you have all of your boxes collected you will be ready to start your project.

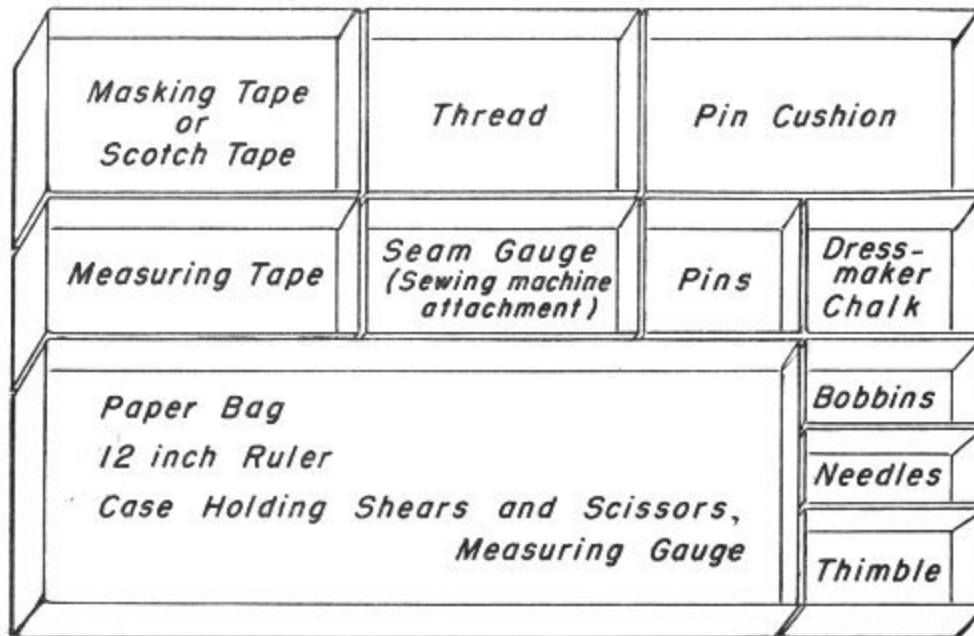
Separate the box tops from the boxes. Then arrange the smaller boxes so they fit into the larger box. Be sure to save enough space for the 12-inch ruler or the length of your shears. Then have mother help you staple or paste the sides of the open boxes together and fasten them into the large box.



To make this box even more useful, you could label each little partition with the names of the tools or supplies you plan to store in each, as shown in the picture of a well organized box on [page 6](#).

If you would rather have a container which could be easily carried from room to room, you might like to buy a fishing tackle box like your brother uses for his supplies. Choosing one with dividers in it will help you to organize your sewing tools very nicely.

Some girls use little doll suitcases, or a small cosmetic case like grown-ups use when traveling. Either of these are very nice, because they are usually pretty in color, and will open up wide so you can see all your sewing tools at one time. They also have a latch to fasten the cover and a handle which makes them easy to carry.



An example of an organized box. The number of small boxes and their arrangement will vary.

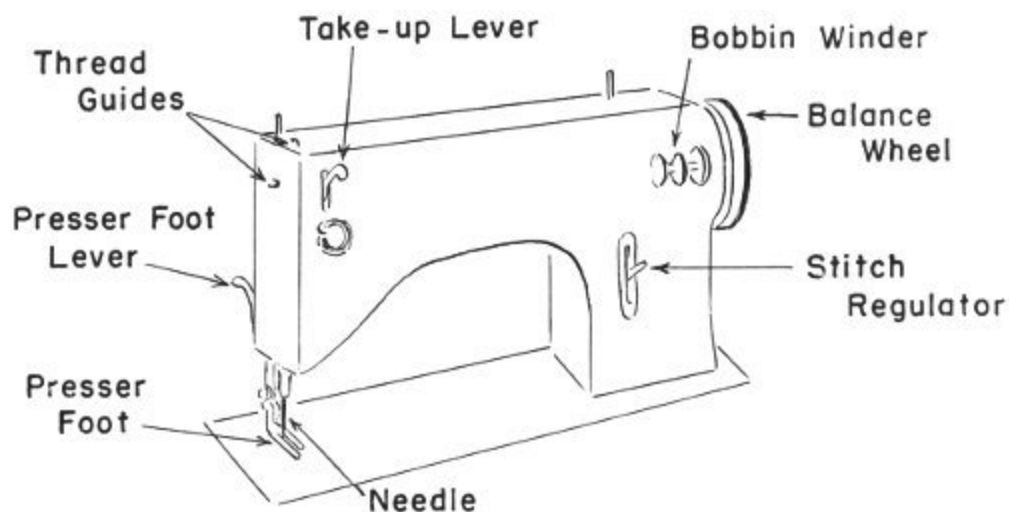
Masking Tape or Scotch Tape
 Thread
 Pin Cushion
 Measuring Tape
 Seam Gauge (Sewing machine attachment)
 Pins
 Dressmaker Chalk
 Bobbins
 Needles
 Thimble
 Paper Bag
 12 inch Ruler
 Case Holding Shears and Scissors, Measuring Gauge

Learn to use mother's sewing machine

What could be more exciting than to learn to use a machine which has “magic power.” Of course, I know when you are older you are going to learn to drive the family car (which you’ve heard dad say has all sorts of magic power). But did you know that mother’s sewing machine has “magic power,” too? The nicest thing is that you do not have to wait until you are grown up to use it. Even though you are only 9 or 10 years old, you are ready to learn the secrets of the sewing machine right now. You will no longer be standing by watching mother or sister sew. Instead, after you have learned some of the secrets of sewing with a machine, you can make many exciting things for yourself, your family, and your friends.

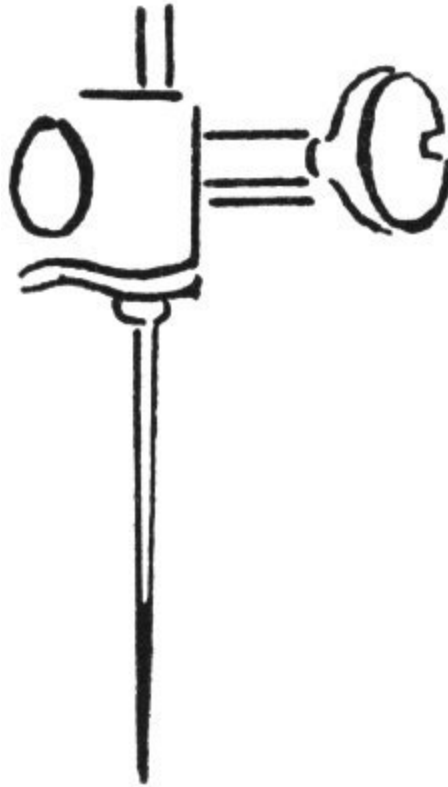
So come—let’s get acquainted with this wonderful machine!

Now look at your sewing machine and find the parts which look similar to the pictures below. Every machine has these parts, though some designs may look just a little different. Your leader will show you how each part works. 7

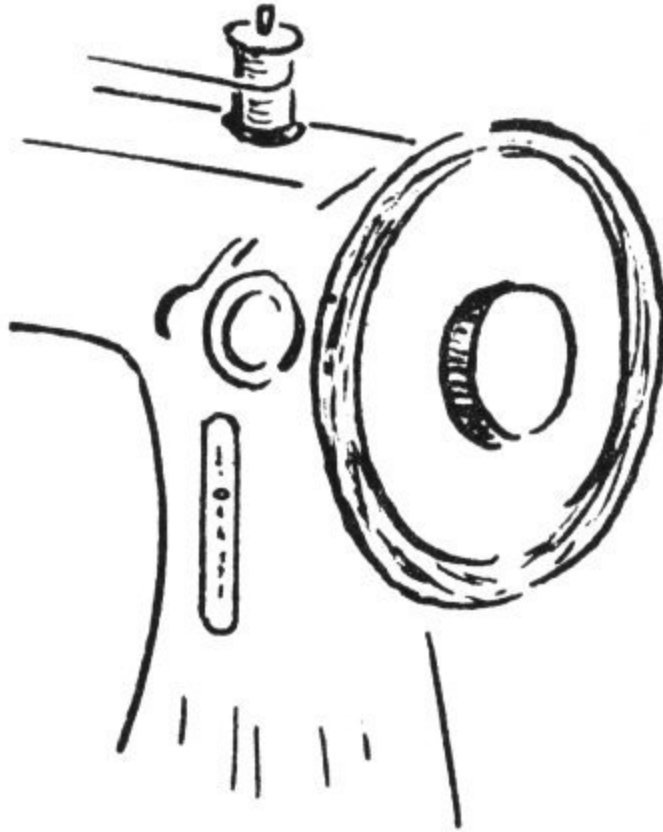


Thread Guides
Take-up Lever
Bobbin Winder
Balance Wheel
Presser Foot Lever
Stitch Regulator
Presser Foot
Needle

Parts of the sewing machine

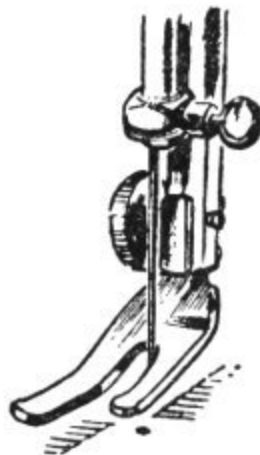


NEEDLE has a long groove in it to guide the thread.

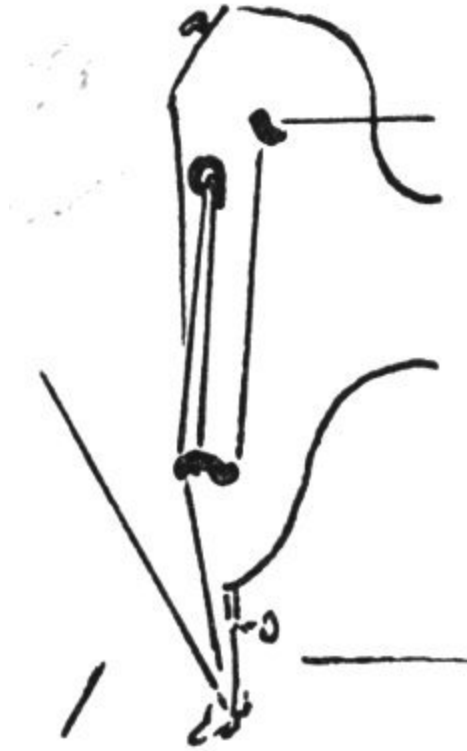


BALANCE WHEEL moves the needle in and out of your material.

8



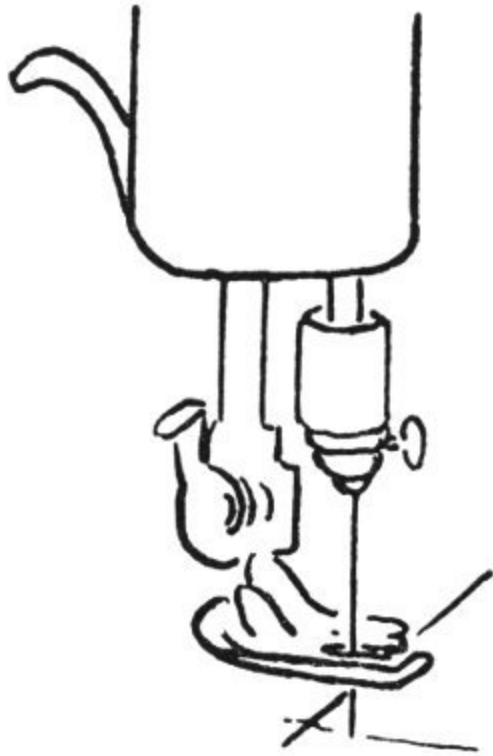
PRESSER FOOT LEVER is the handle which moves the presser foot up and down.



THREAD GUIDES hold the thread in place as it is being unwound from the spool during stitching.



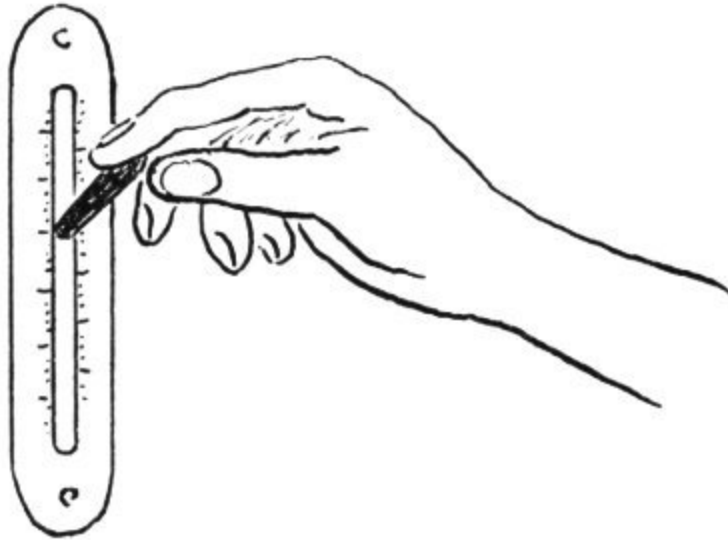
TAKE-UP LEVER pulls the thread from the spool as it moves up and down with the needle.



PRESSER FOOT holds the material so the needle can sew through it.

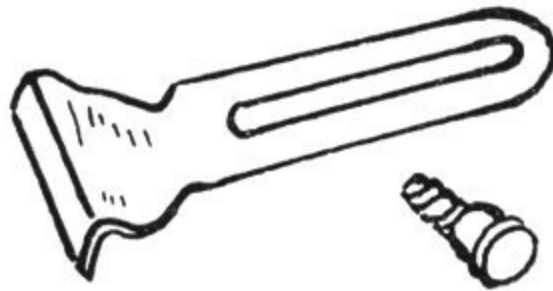


BOBBIN WINDER winds the thread from the spool onto the bobbin (spool which holds thread in lower machine).



STITCH REGULATOR makes stitches small or large. Also adjusts the machine to move your material forward or backward.

9



CLOTH GUIDE ATTACHMENT helps to stitch straight seams.

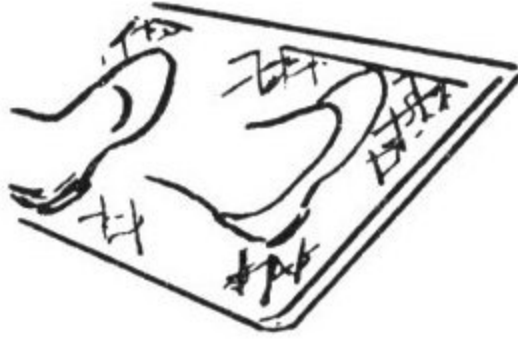
Types of control levers



FOOT CONTROL



KNEE LEVER



TREADLE

How to use the sewing machine

Is your chair the right height?

- Can you see the needle easily as it moves up and down?
- Are you able to reach behind the needle?
- Can you rest your arms on the table?
- Do your feet touch the floor?



If you cannot see the needle or rest your arms on the table, you will need a taller chair or something to sit on to raise you up a bit. If your feet do not touch the floor (after you are sitting in the position to see the needle) and your machine has a foot control you will have to find a sturdy box. It should be large enough to rest both of your feet, as well as the foot control from the machine.

10

How to start and stop the machine

With your machine unthreaded and the presser foot raised, it is ready for you to start. Place your right hand on the balance wheel. (It will help you to start the machine in motion.)

Keep your left hand a distance from the needle to avoid this—



How to speed up and slow down

Place your foot or knee on the control or treadle.

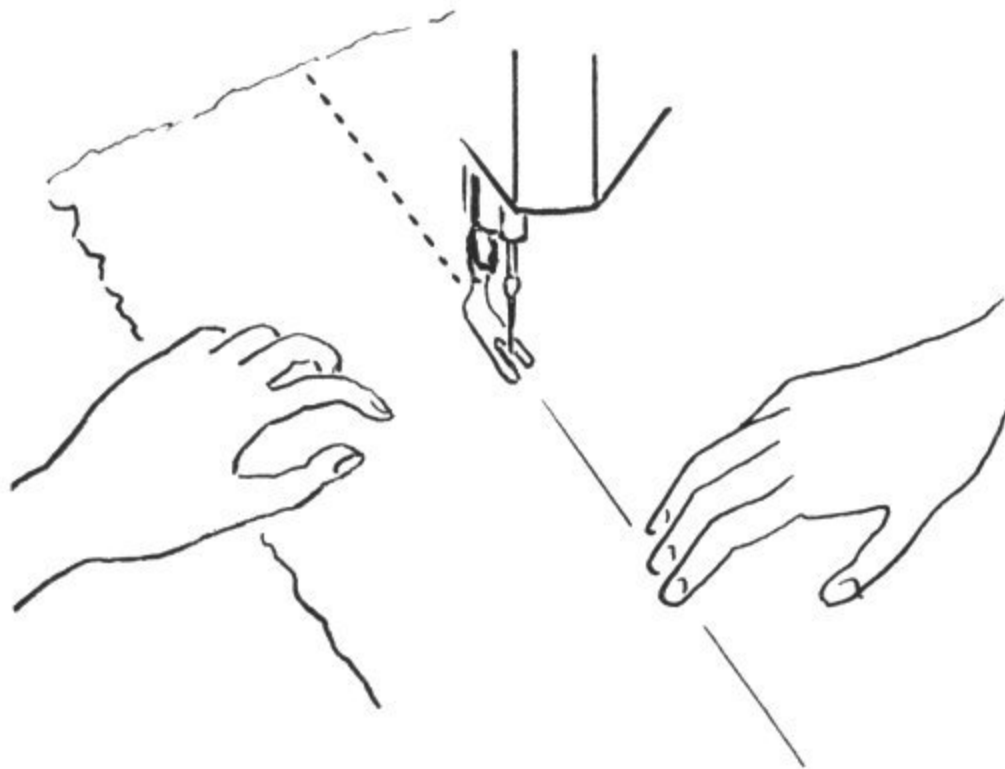
See how slowly you can make the needle go up and down. If the machine runs too fast for you, you can press your right hand against the balance wheel to slow it down.

Practice until your foot or knee can control the speed evenly from fast to slow, without using your right hand on the balance wheel.

How to stitch correctly

Slip a piece of material under the presser foot. (Your leader will have a piece for you.) Lower the needle into the material by rolling your right hand on the balance wheel until the needle goes down as far as possible. Then lower the presser foot onto the material.

Let the machine run without your hands touching the material. You will notice that it will slip and slide in many directions. To guide the material, hold your left hand on it with your fingers curved as if you were holding a ball in your hand. If you hold it gently, you can guide the material as it slips under your fingers without interrupting its movement as it is being sewn. Try it!



Your right hand will also help you to guide the material. As soon as the machine is in motion, take your right hand off the balance wheel. You will soon discover that you will have to practice the trick of sewing straight.

**Do not run off the EDGE
of material.**

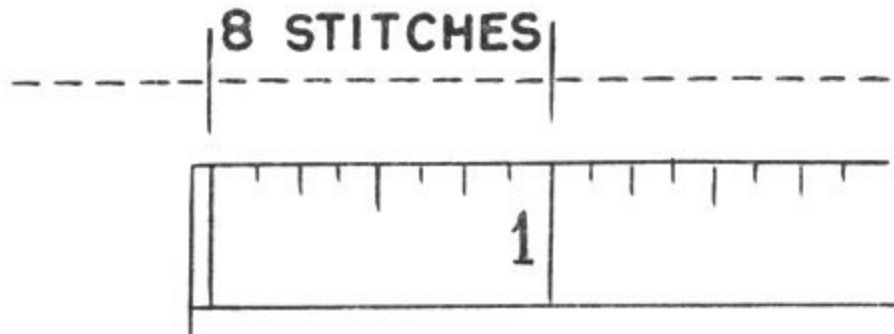
Slow down your speed when you near the end of your material so that you can stop when you reach the edge. Roll the balance wheel to raise the needle—then lift the presser foot to remove the material.

How to use the stitch regulator

If your sewing machine has a lever which makes it sew backward, try to use it now. Move the stitch regulator up as far as it will go. As you start the machine you will see it moving backward. In order to stitch forward again, push the lever back down as far as it will go. As you will learn in your projects, you will always have to sew very slowly and carefully when 11 you sew backward in order to do it nicely.



Another reason the stitch regulator is on your machine is to make the stitches larger or smaller for you, whichever is best for the material with which you are working.

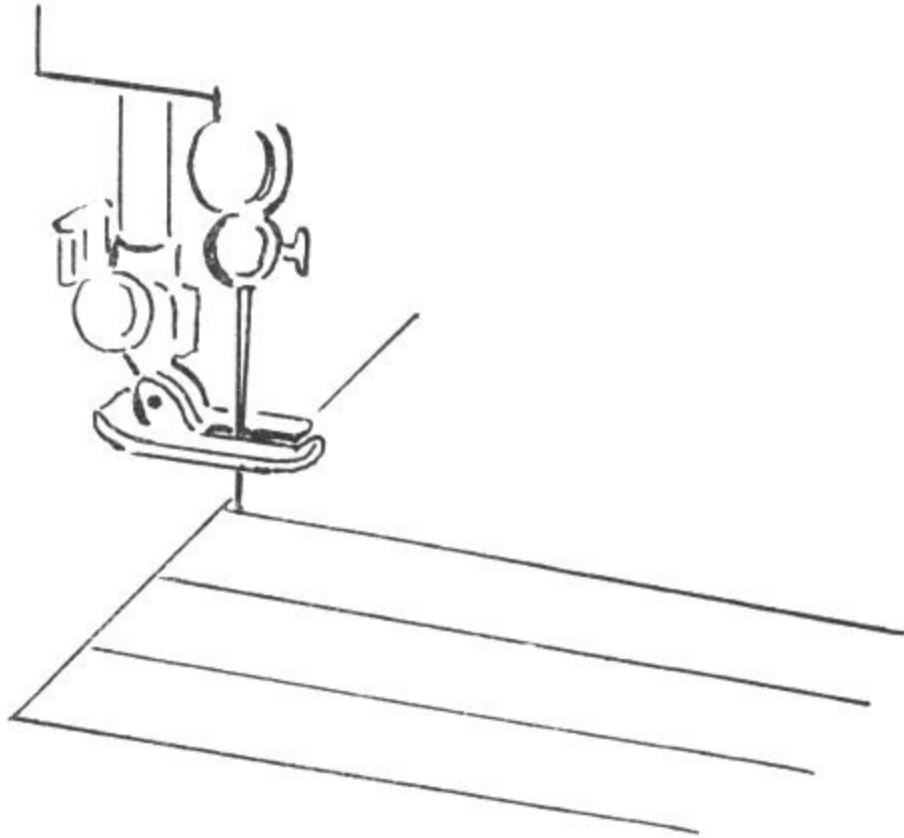


Some machines have numbers next to the lever to tell you the number of stitches per inch. If your machine does not have such numbers, you will be able to tell the number of stitches per inch by putting a line of stitching into a piece of material, and counting the number of stitches sewn in a one-inch space.

How to practice stitching

Mark some straight and curved lines on your piece of material. (Paper may also be used but it dulls the needle; material is best.)

Roll the balance wheel to lower the needle at the end of one of the lines. Lower the presser foot and start the machine. Slowly stitch the entire line (without thread), guiding your material so the needle follows the line as much as possible. Practice stitching along a marked line without thread, going backward and forward with both small and large stitches.



When you can control the speed of the machine and stitch straight, you have learned some important secrets of mother's sewing. Soon you will be ready to start on your first project.

How to thread the machine

Would you like to be able to thread the machine as easily as your leader threads it? Ask her to do it very slowly for you so you can learn it from her. Watch closely as she hooks the thread onto every finger of each thread guide until she finally reaches the needle. She will also show you where the bobbin hides (remember this is the flat spool in the lower part of the machine) and how you will get its thread to the top of the machine.

After you have threaded the machine be sure to have your leader check it before you try to sew. If you want the machine to “work like magic” you

will have to have it threaded correctly.

Stitching with a threaded machine

You have probably learned how to follow a marked line very well by this time. It is also important to see that you will be able to do as well when you actually stitch with thread.

Enjoy good sewing habits

Hint number 1

The first important hint to know
is—“Join the Clean Clan Club” whenever you sew!



Hands freshly washed and nails clean, too
will help keep your projects looking like new.

Clean clothes—“a must” while handling cloth,
for fear some dust and grime may rub off.

Last of all—your table must gleam
to protect nice materials from soil unseen.

So—*Clean Hands, Clean Clothes, Clean Table*, too,
is an important trick for you.

Hint number 2

“The Clean Clan Clubs” can boastful be
of unsoiled projects, delightful to see.

But here’s another hint for you—
to keep you from wrinkling your fabrics so new.

Your lap’s too small and too far away
to hold your project by night or by day.

But—your table clean would love to hold
the bulk of that fabric, while you pin that fold.



So,—trick number 2, in this sewing trade
is—*work on a table* to get your projects made.

Hint number 3

Here's one last, special hint for you—
and something easy we would like you to do.

Look at yourself—as you start to sew.
How do you sit? And how are your feet below?

Think of your posture—it's no chore—
to keep your back straight, with both feet on the floor.

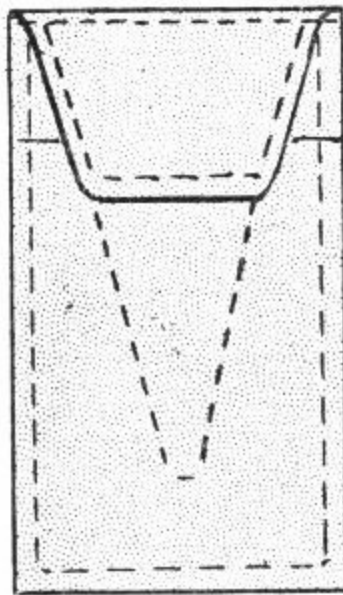
You won't get tired so quickly then
and you'll enjoy stitching again and again.

Start to sew

If you have learned to run the sewing machine smoothly, and to thread it correctly, you are ready to start making something useful.

A shears case

The first article you will make is a shears case. It can be used to store your shears in your sewing box. This will help remind you that these are special shears and should be used only for cutting fabric. Cutting paper will make them dull.



The first article you will make is a “Shears Case”

A shears case will protect the sharp points from being damaged by hitting other tools in the box. It will also protect your fingers when you reach for your shears or for your other sewing tools.

What you will learn

- To recognize the feel and appearance of felt or nonwoven interfacing.
- To choose and buy pretty material and thread.
- To read ruler measurements.
- To make a pattern according to measurements.
- To pin a pattern to the material.
- To handle the shears when cutting material.
- To use tailor's chalk or a tailor's pencil for marking around the pattern.
- To use the stitch regulator for backstitching and adjusting the size of stitches.
- To use the toe of the presser foot as a marked line for stitching straight.
- To make a hem and stitch it.

What you will do first

To make a shears case you will need to buy felt or nonwoven interfacing (suit-weight), thread, and tailor's chalk or pencil.

If your shears are 8 inches or less in length, the felt swatches (9 inches wide and 12 inches long) sold in many stores are a good buy. If your shears are over 8 inches long see [page 14](#) for directions. Ask your leader or your mother to help you decide how much fabric you will need.

If it is easy for you to stitch straight, try a color of thread which is different from your material to add color to your case.

If you are still having difficulty stitching on a straight line, it would be better to use thread which matches your material because mistakes will be less easy to see. You can use either regular or heavy duty thread.

Tools and supplies you will need to make the case are as follows.

Pencil
12-inch ruler
Paper shears
Fabric

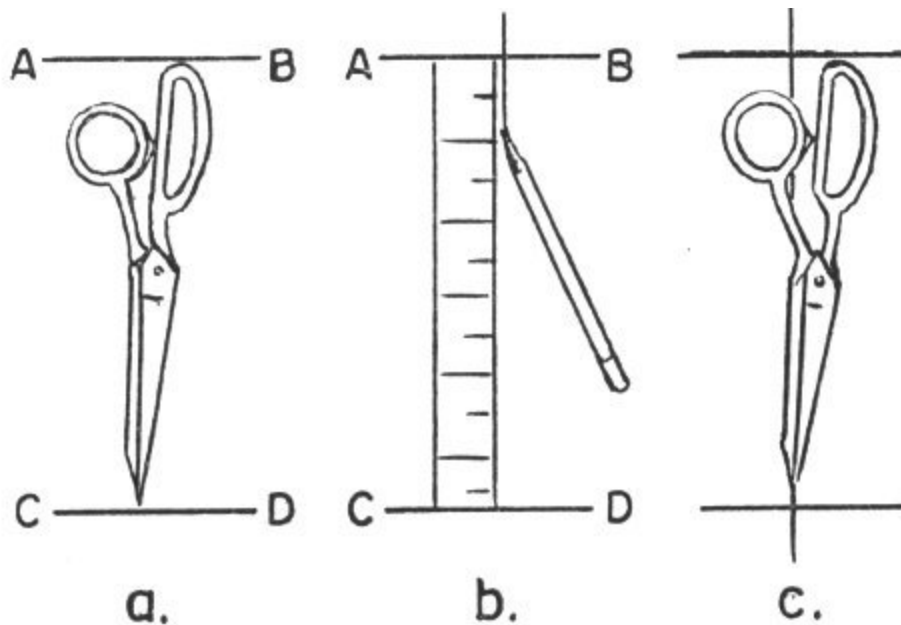
Paper
Thread
Bobbin
Tailor's chalk or tailor's pencil
Shears

How to make the shears case

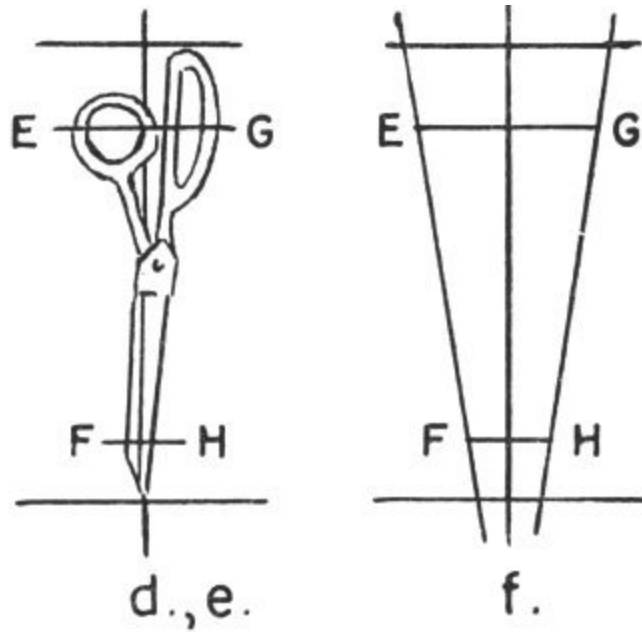
Make a paper pattern

Measure the length of your shears on a piece of paper. Mark this length with lines AB and CD. Then draw a vertical line between these two lines by placing a ruler on the lines as shown.

14



Measure the width of the shears by placing them on the vertical line so that the intersection of the handles and the points of the shears rest on the line.

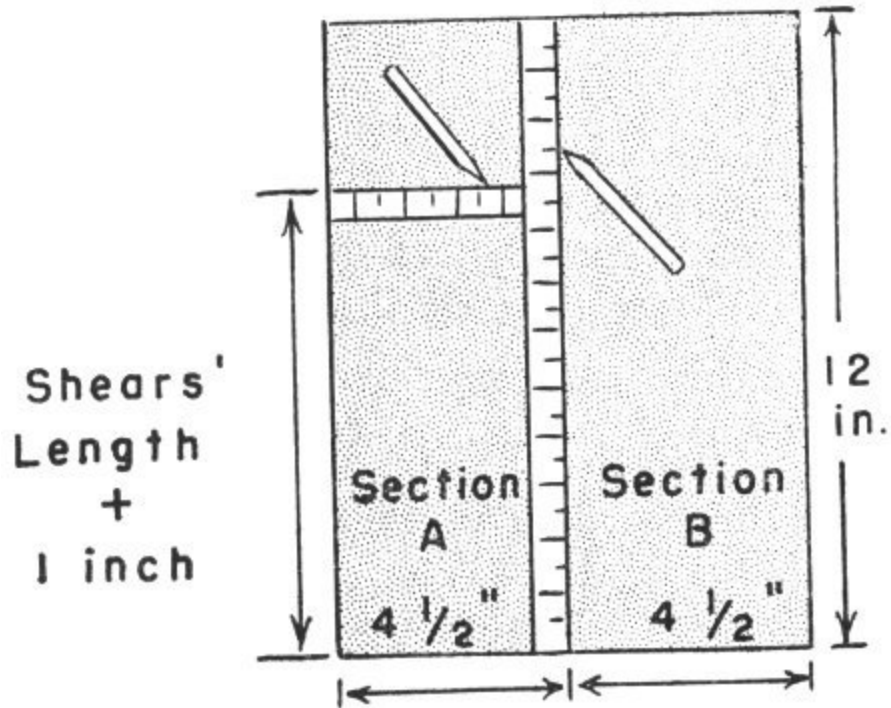


Measure across the widest part of the handles. (Ask your leader to help you read the ruler.) Label points E and G. Also measure the width $\frac{1}{2}$ inch from the point of the shears. Label these two points as F and H.

Make a pattern for the pocket by drawing lines with your ruler, from point E to F and G to H. Extend these lines to the full length of the shears.

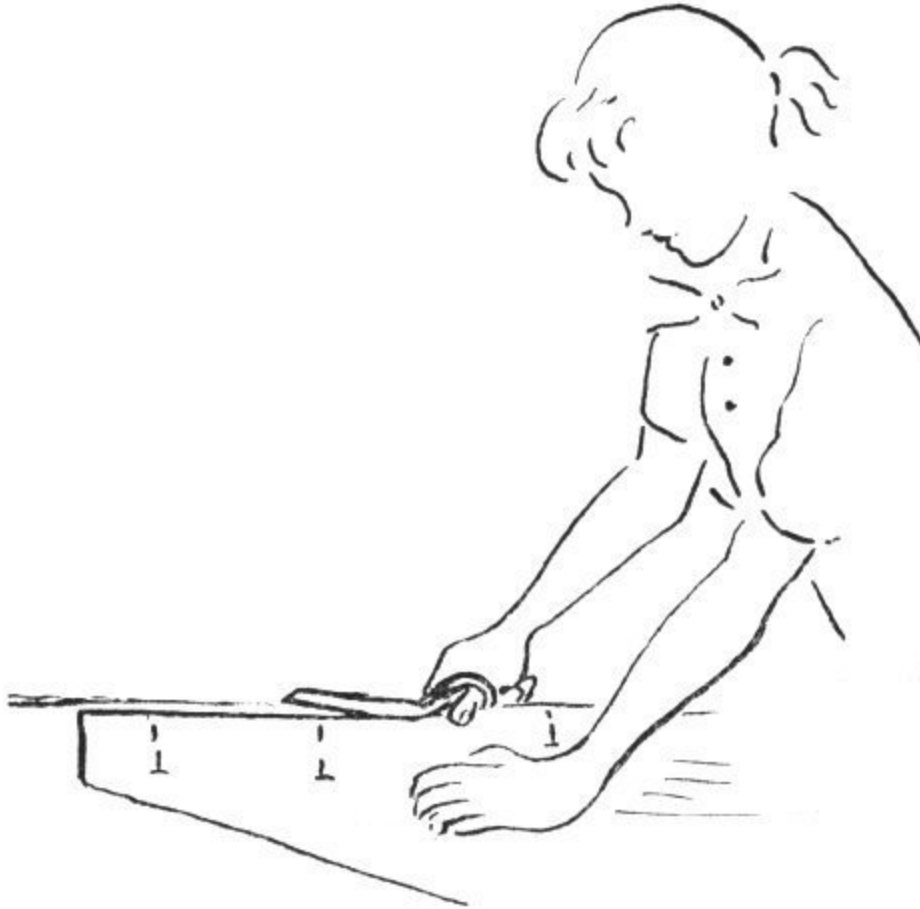
Mark the fabric; follow the illustration

Use your ruler to measure and mark your fabric. It is most important that you are careful to measure accurately and mark very straight lines. Use tailor's chalk or tailor's pencil for marking. Then ask your leader to check your material and your markings. They must be perfectly marked to prevent trouble when you sew the case together later.



Cut the fabric

Since cutting material, especially heavy material like felt or nonwoven interfacing, is different than cutting paper, practice on some scraps of material before you cut the fabric for the case. You will have the best cut edge if you open the shears wide and take long even strokes in cutting. Do not close the points of the shears until you reach the end of the pattern or the material. Cut the piece of fabric along the marked lines.

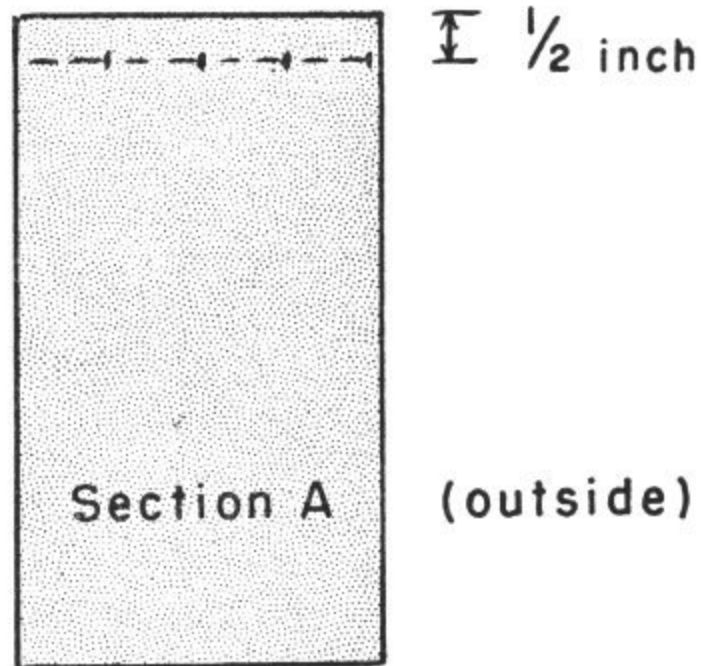


ALWAYS HOLD AND CUT MATERIAL ON THE TABLE

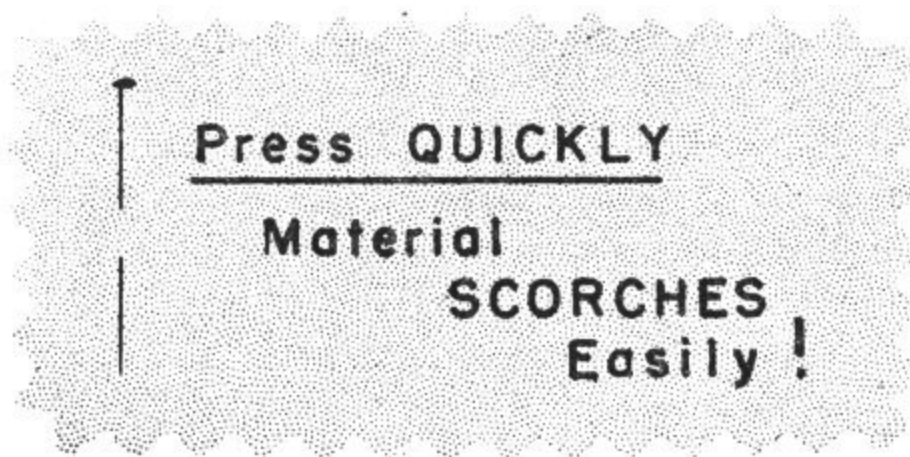
15

Mark the hem on section A

A hem (material folded back on itself) is needed on the top edge of Section A to make the top strong enough so it will not tear when the shears are slipped into the pocket.

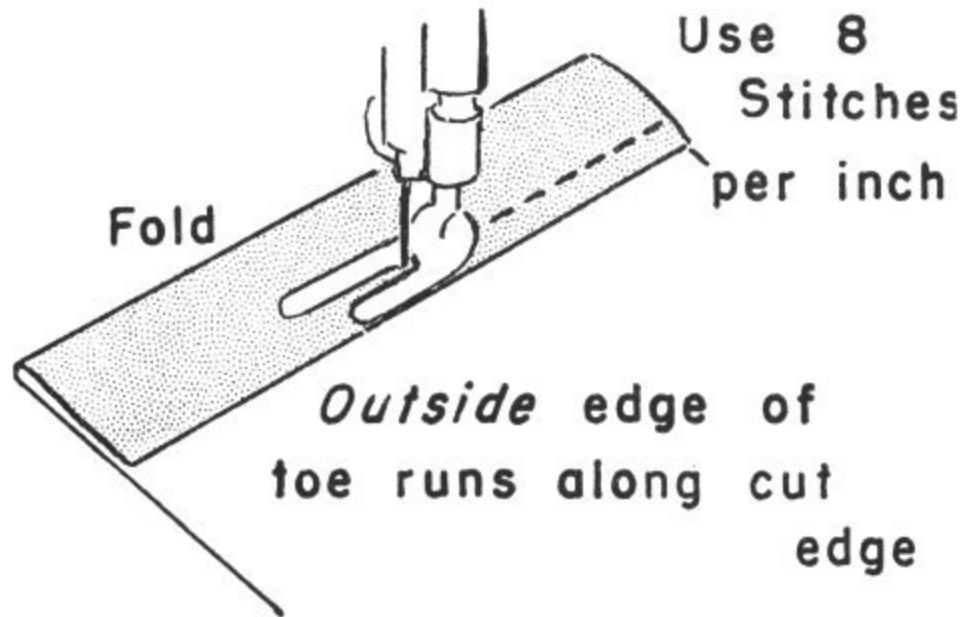


Measure $\frac{1}{2}$ inch from the top edge of section A. Mark with pins. Then fold the edge down so the pins lie on the outside of the fold. Press a fold along the pins. Ask your leader to show you how to press with a steam iron or a pressing cloth.



You have learned to stitch straight by following a line. When you stitch this hem your presser foot *not the needle* will follow a line. Place your material

under the presser foot with the cut edge touching the inside edge of the toe of the presser foot. Your leader will show you how this is done.

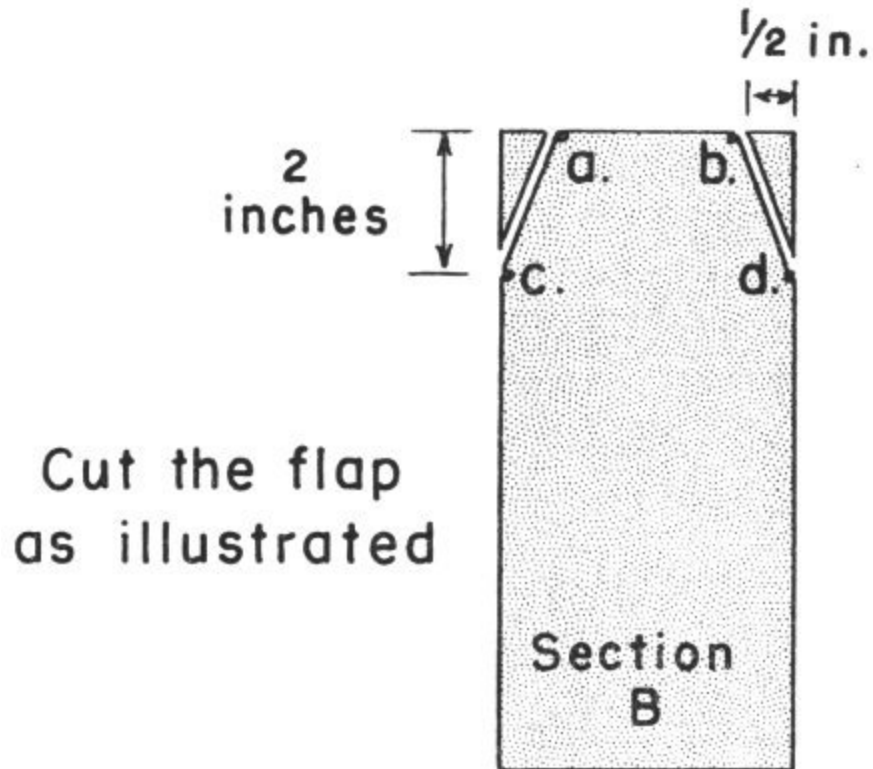


Fold

Use 8 Stitches per inch

Outside edge of toe runs along cut edge

You may want to practice before stitching the hem into this part of your shears case. Look back to [page 10](#) if you have forgotten how to start and end a line of stitching.



Shape the flap of section B

In order to neatly fold the top of section B over the shears, and also to make the shears case more interesting, cut the flap as shown above.

Measure $\frac{1}{2}$ inch from the sides of fabric piece B—points a and b. Then measure 2 inches from the top of section B—points c and d.

Using a ruler, draw a straight line between points a and c and points b and d. Cut along a-c and b-d with long, even strokes.

16

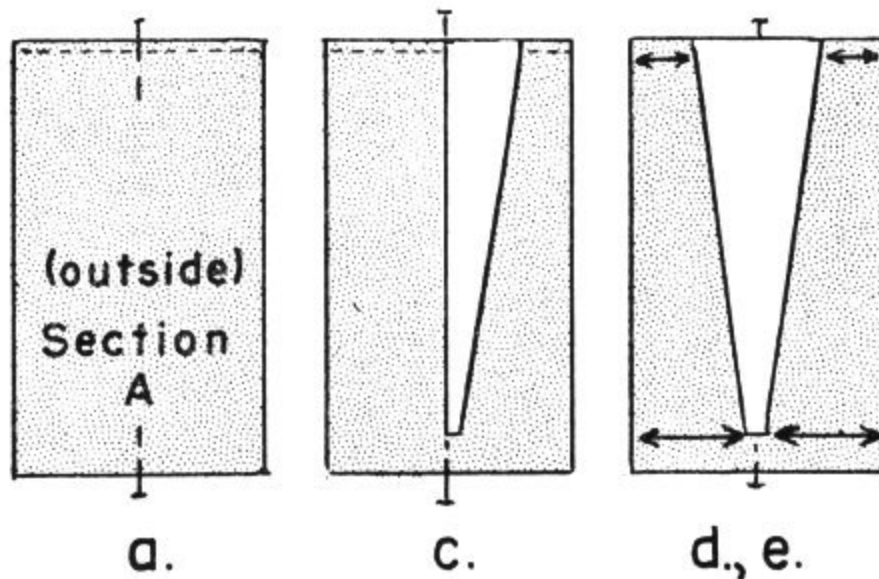
Mark the pocket on section A

Fold section A in half. Carefully put pins into the fold to mark the center. Fold the pocket pattern, which you cut earlier, in half. Place the center crease of the pocket pattern on the pins marking the center of section A.

The top edge of the pattern should be even with hemline (folded edge) of section A.

Open the pocket pattern and pin it in place. Measure the distance between the paper pattern and the outer edge of section A at the top and bottom of the pattern.

Trace around the pattern with tailor's chalk or your tailor's pencil. Keep the chalk line very sharp, because you will be using it as a guide for stitching the pocket.

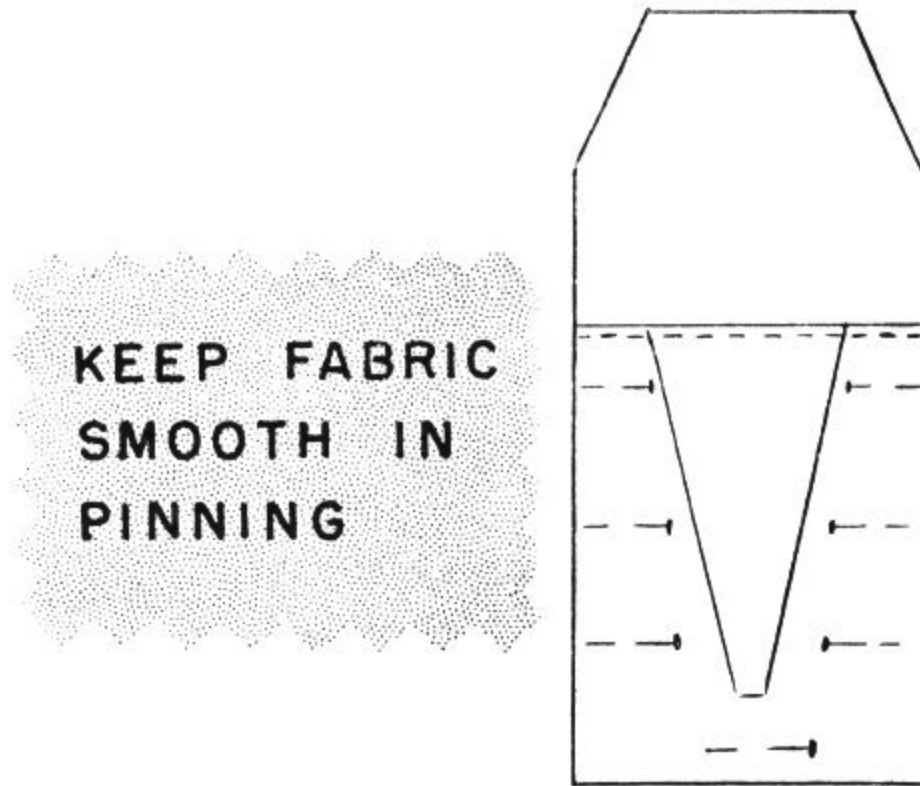


Get the pocket ready to stitch

To make the pocket, you will be stitching section A and section B together. Since two thicknesses of fabric are more bulky than a single thickness, it will be necessary to learn how to pin them together so they will not slip when you are stitching them.

Place section A over section B with cut edges of lower corners and side edges matching. The hem should be folded to the inside and chalk markings to the outside.

Pin the two pieces together with the points of the pins directed to the side edges of the case.



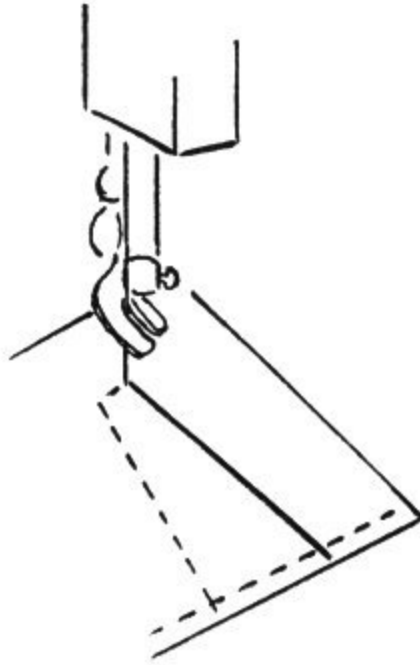
Machine stitch the pocket

Adjust the stitch regulator to 8 stitches per inch. Lower the needle on the stitched hemline of section A. Lower the presser foot after the threads have been drawn between the toes to the back of the machine.

Backstitch until the needle pierces folded edge, or knot the thread according to directions on [page 21](#). Then adjust the stitch regulator to forward motion.

Stitch following the line you have marked, stitching on it as much as possible. Apply little pressure onto the knee lever or foot pedal so the machine will not move too fast.

When you reach the point of the pocket, lower the needle into the point of material, raise the presser foot, turn the material around, lower the presser foot again, and stitch to the next point. The presser foot needs to be raised and lowered in this manner each time you want to turn a corner.



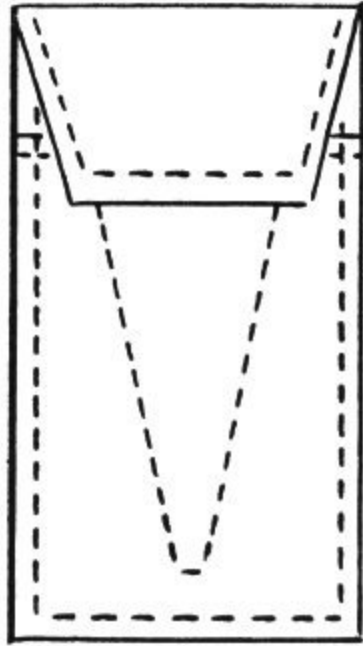
Stitch to the fold of the hem. When you reach the fold, backstitch to the stitching line of the hem.

17

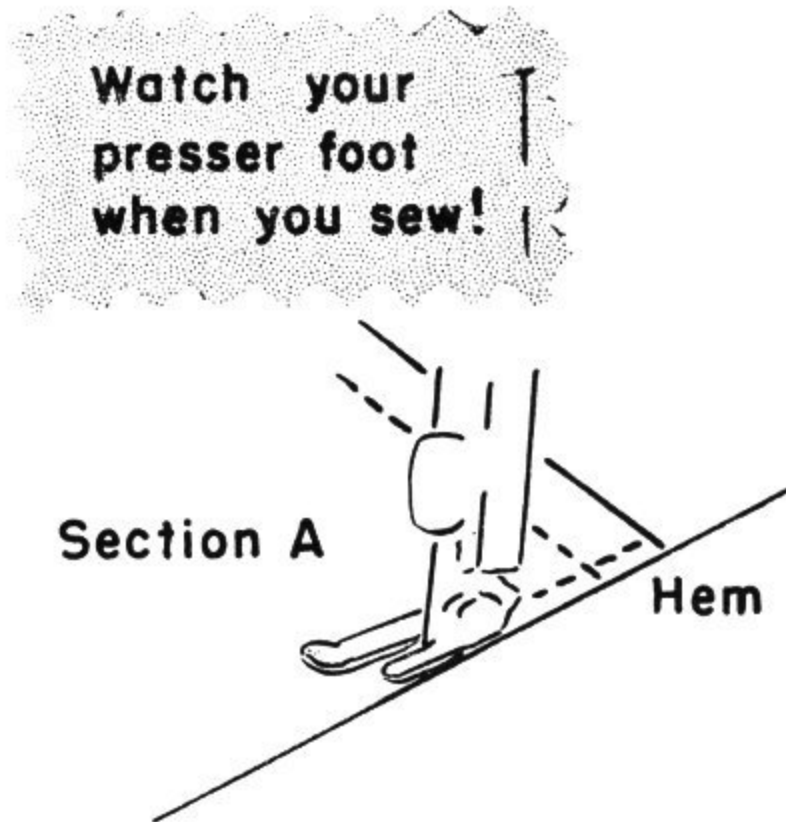
With your small scissors clip the threads close to the stitching line.

Sew sections A and B together

The side seams of the case must still be stitched together. This is done on the outside of the case.



Place your shears case under the presser foot so that the cut edges are even with the outside of the narrow toe. Start stitching in the hem of section A.



When you reach each corner remember to turn your wheel by *hand* so the needle goes into the material at the exact turning point. Turn corner as you learned on [page 16](#). Do not try to use the electricity when reaching or turning corners until you know how to use the machine as easily and as accurately as your mother or leader.

After you have stitched around the entire case, sew over the first stitches you made in the hem.

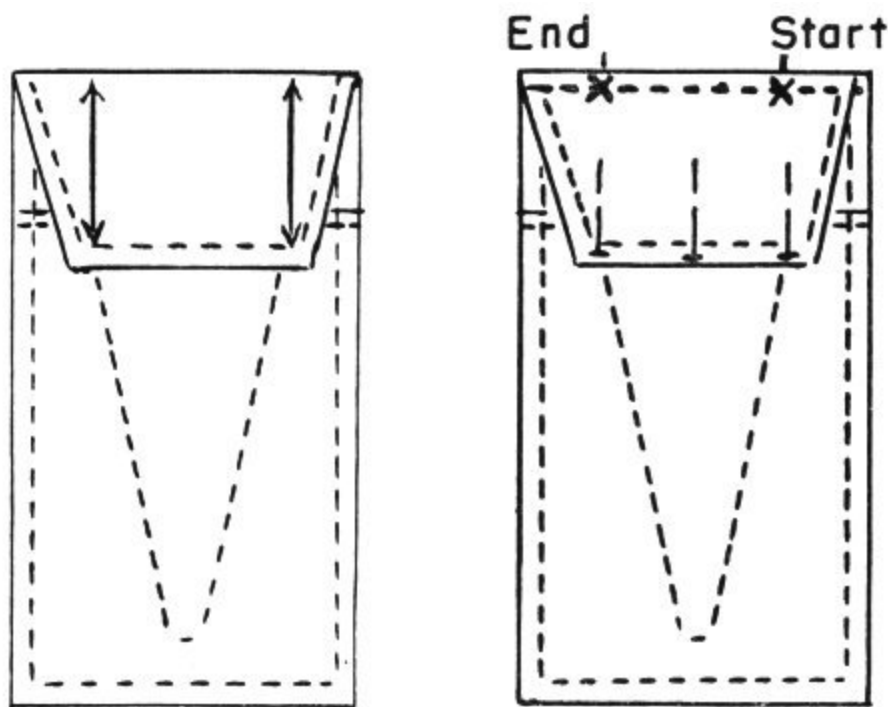
Clip the threads short. (Are you remembering to put the clipped threads into the paper bag fastened to your machine?)

Change the top of section B into a flap

In order to keep the upper part of section B in a folded position so it will keep the shears in the pocket, you need to add one more row of stitching.

Slip the shears into the pocket of the case. Then turn section B down over the shears to find the best place to fold the flap. Mark the fold with a pin.

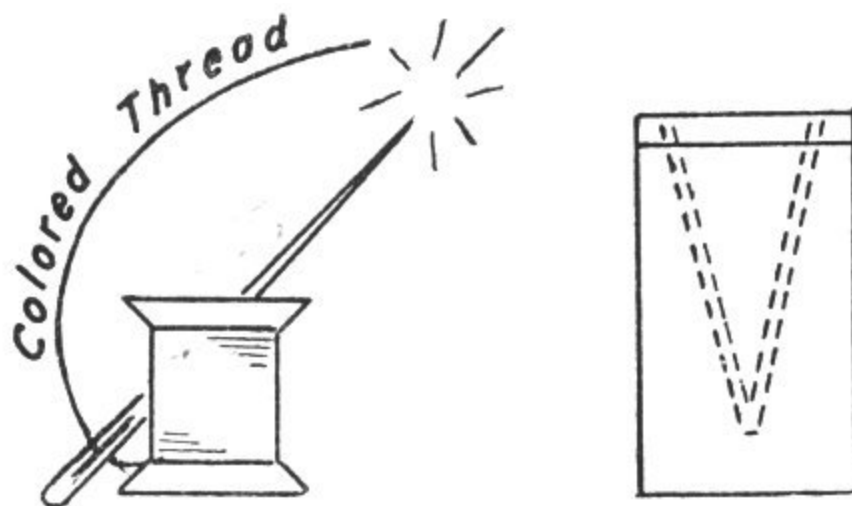
Remove the shears and fold the flap on the empty case. Measure the distance from the fold to the cut edge in several places, to be sure it is folded evenly. Then press the fold lightly and pin into position.



Machine stitch $\frac{1}{8}$ inch from the fold of the flap, backstitching up to the stitching line, and then moving forward.

Clip your threads closely, remove pins, and you have completed your first project!

Now that you have learned to measure and to use your sewing machine accurately, you will find a great deal of enjoyment in combining thread of a color contrasting with your material. Stitching then becomes a decoration. If you are really able to stitch straight, stitch each pocket twice—each row $\frac{1}{8}$ inch apart, or the width of the presser foot toe.



You have a pattern and have learned how simple it is to make this handy case. Why not make a few more for gifts?

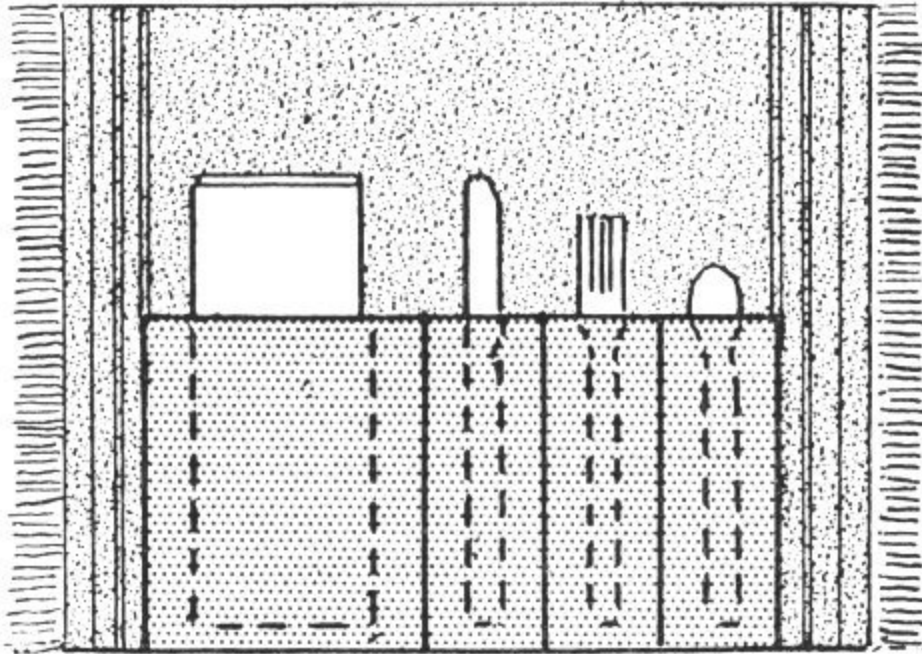
You could please your mother, or some of your friends, if you made a case for their shears, too.

Barbecue placemats or traveling kit

This project will give you more practice in using the parts of the sewing machine you have learned to use in making your shears case. You may choose to make either placemats or a traveling kit or both. The materials and supplies used for each are the same, and most of the stitching is the same. But the number and size of pockets, as well as the use of the article are different. Your bulletin shows you how to make the pockets for each article.

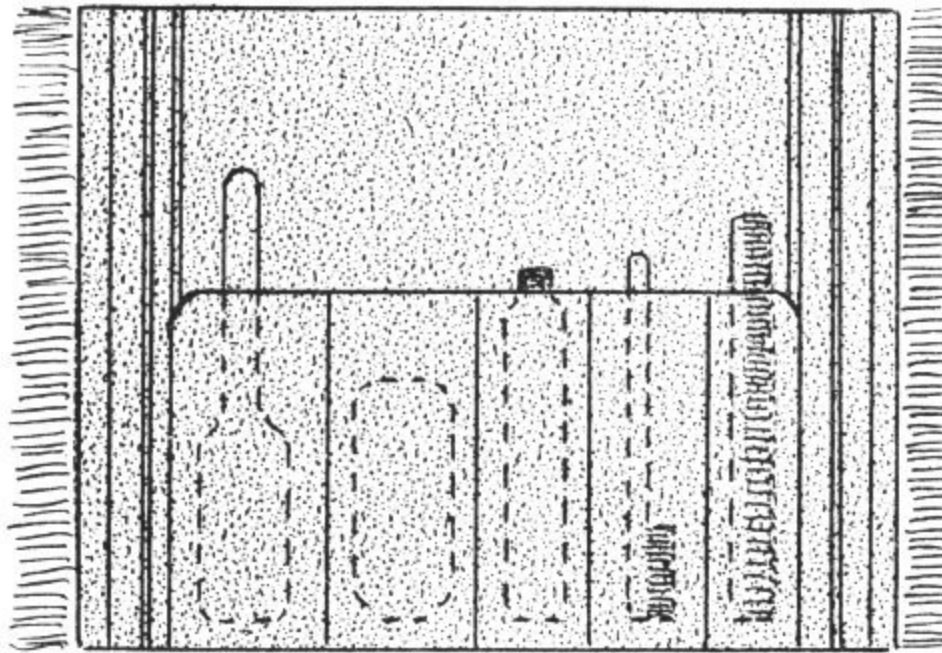
Barbecue placemats

When rolled and tied barbecue placemats are easy carryalls for napkins and silverware for a barbecue meal. When open, they are placemats.



Traveling kit

A traveling kit will hold some of the articles you need in order to be well groomed when you visit your friends—your toothbrush, toothpaste, comb, hairbrush, hand lotion, kleenex, etc. Or it can be used to hold some of the supplies you need to keep your clothes well groomed when you are traveling, such as a clothes brush, shoe polish, and shoe brush.



What you will learn

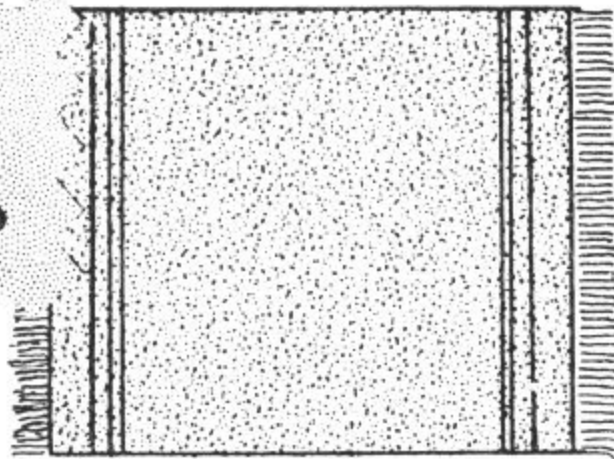
- To choose and match pretty colors.
- To do some hand basting.
- To stitch a seam.
- To top-stitch (stitching one piece of material on top of another).
- To stitch straight by following a line in the design of the material.

19

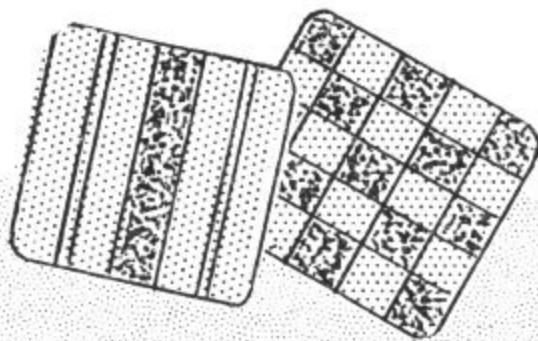
What you will do first

You will need to go shopping with your mother to buy the towels, washcloths, shoestrings, and thread.

Will this color
look nice with
Mother's dishes?

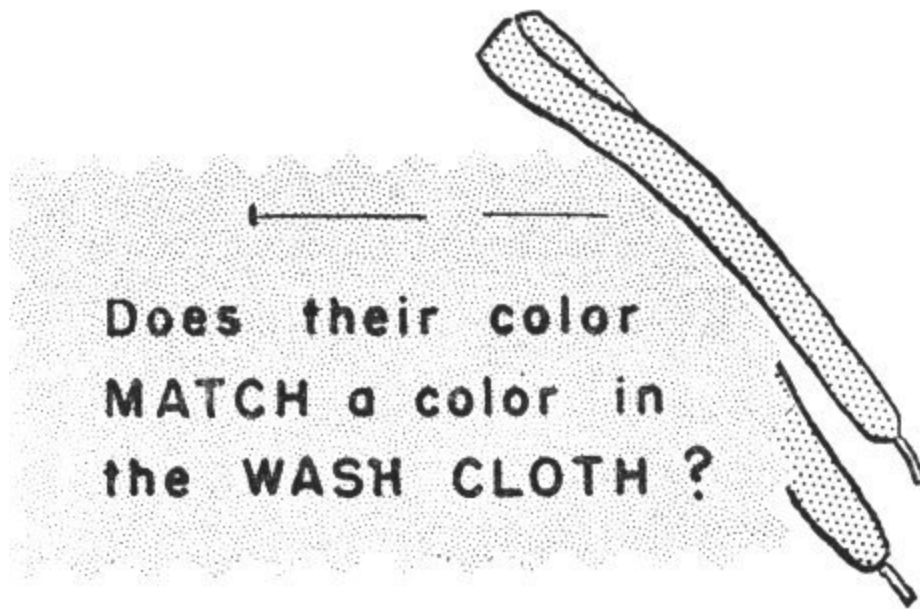


Two plain-colored, terry cloth finger towels.



Does one color
MATCH your towel?

One striped or checked washcloth (the design will be your guide in stitching).



One pair of plain colored shoestrings—27 inches long.

Two spools of thread; 1 to match stripes and shoestrings and 1 to match the towels.

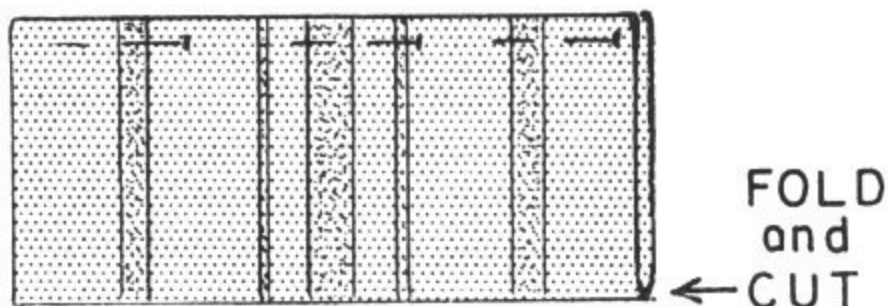
You will also need these tools from your sewing box:

- Large shears
- Pins and pincushion
- Thimble
- Paper bag
- 21-inch ruler
- Needle
- Scissors

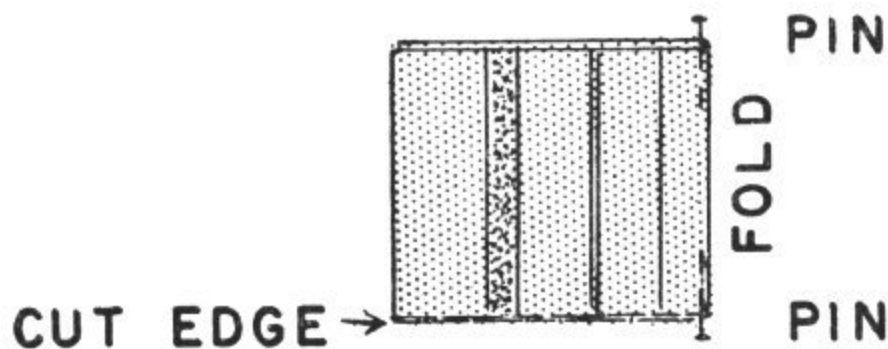
Take another good peek at what your placemat will look like when you are finished ([page 18](#)). In order to clearly show how you will stitch the washcloth to the towel, a plain washcloth is used in the illustrations instead of a checked or striped one like you will be using in your project.

Start with the washcloth

Fold the washcloth in half with the stripes running up and down. Then pin the open edges together with 3 or 4 pins.



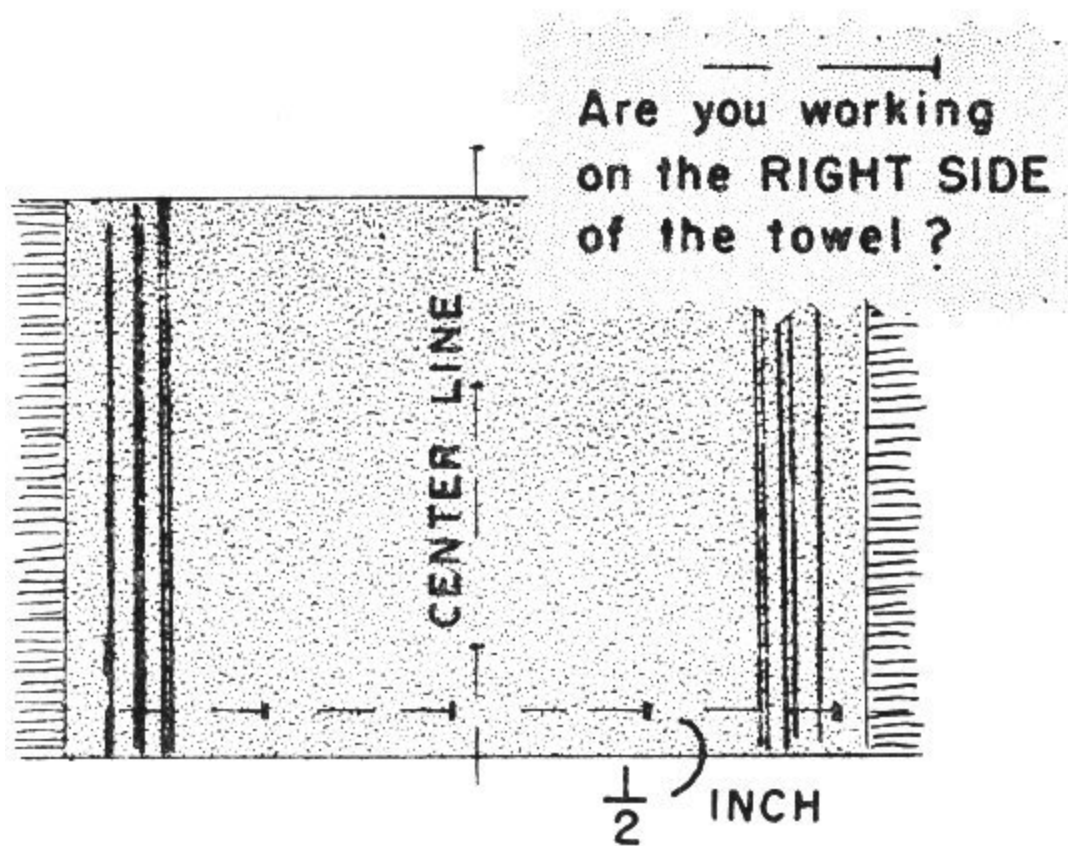
Use shears to cut through the fold of the washcloth to cut it in half. (Your leader will show you how to handle the shears so that you can take long, even cutting strokes.)



Fold each half washcloth again to find the center. Mark the center with a pin at the cut edge and on the hem edge.

Get the towels ready

Find the center of the towels by folding each in half—crosswise and right side out. (If you do not recognize the right side of the towel, ask your leader to help you.)



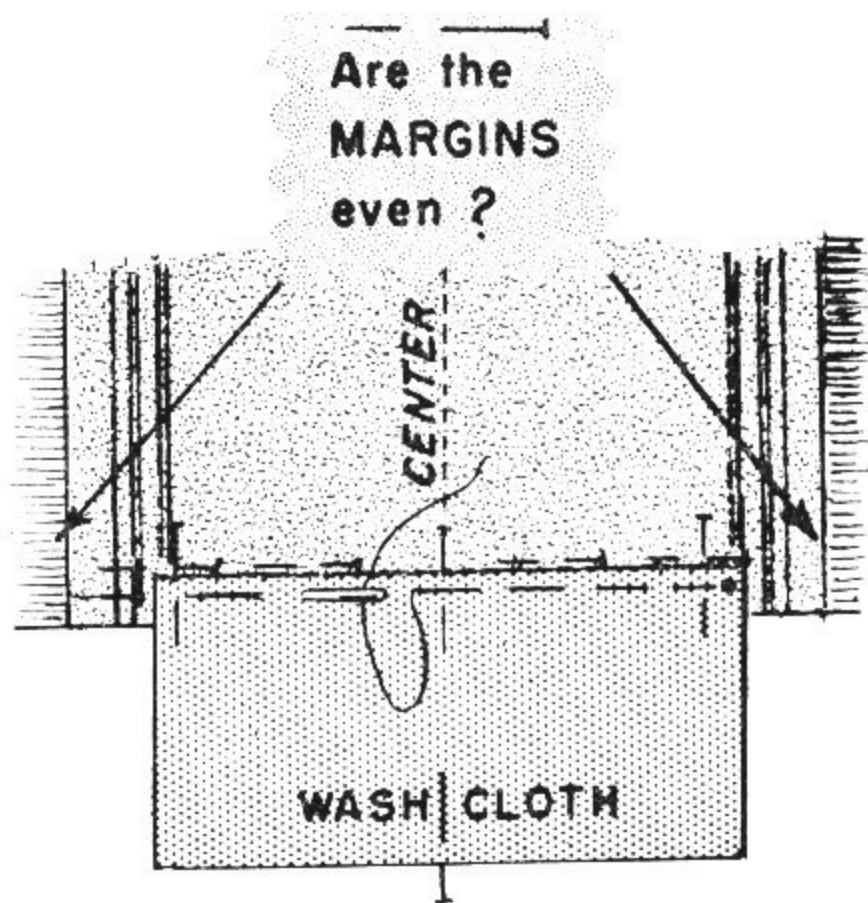
Mark the center of each towel with pins, as you did the washcloth. But since the towel is bigger than the washcloth, you will need at least three pins on the fold to mark the center line. Also insert a row of pins on the right side of the towel, $\frac{1}{2}$ inch from the lower hem of the towel.

Sew the washcloth and towel together

Find the place for the washcloth on the towel by matching the center of the washcloth with the center of the towel. Then bring the cut edge of the washcloth up to the row of pins.

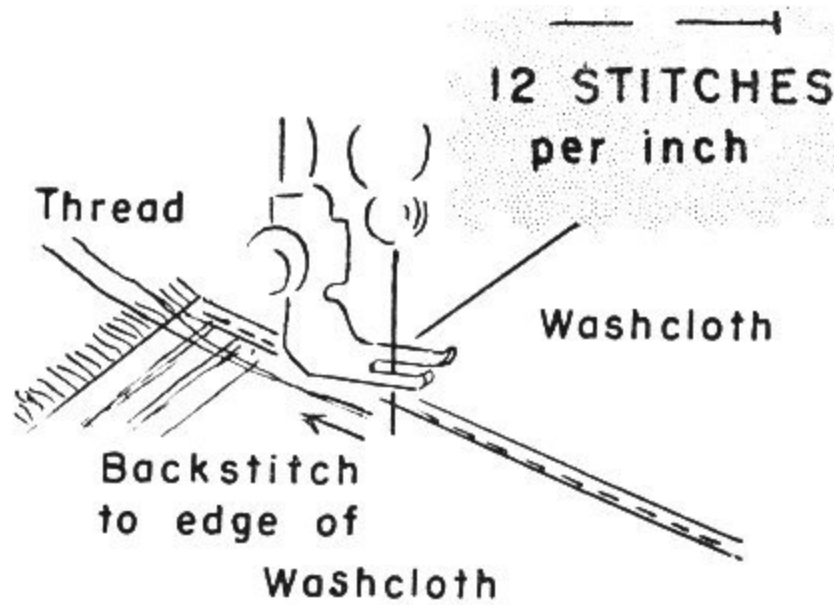
Pin the washcloth in place as shown in the illustration. Sew a hand-basting stitch along the hem of the towel to hold the washcloth in place when stitching it with the sewing machine. Since many of you have never sewn

by hand, your leader will give you a special demonstration on how to thread the needle and baste. Try to keep the stitches about $\frac{1}{4}$ inch in length.



Stitch the washcloth to the towel from the wrong side of the towel. You will be making a $\frac{1}{4}$ inch seam, or you might stitch just to the inside of the hem. Your leader will show you where your stitching line looks best.

Adjust the stitch regulator to sew backward. If your sewing machine cannot be adjusted to go in reverse, raise your presser foot slightly above the fabric at the edge of the washcloth and take 4 or 5 stitches. The fabric will not move but the thread will become knotted and fastened.



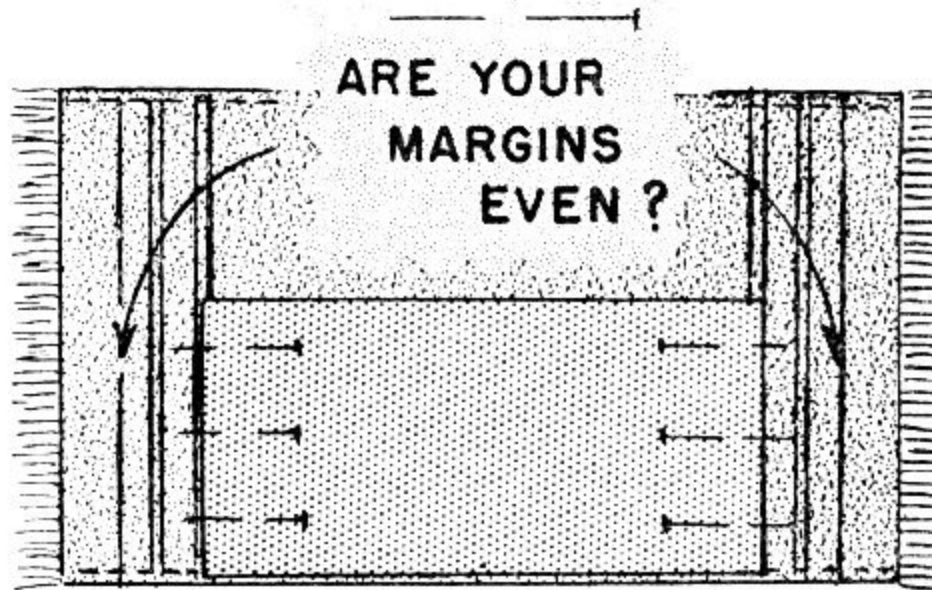
Lower the needle into the towel at a point $\frac{1}{4}$ inch from the side hem of the washcloth. Keep both threads to the back of the presser foot. Then lower the presser foot.

Start to use the machine by turning the fly wheel by hand until the needle reaches the edge of the washcloth. Adjust the stitch regulator so the machine will sew forward again—12 stitches per inch. Stitch (using electricity) until you reach the other side of the washcloth. 21

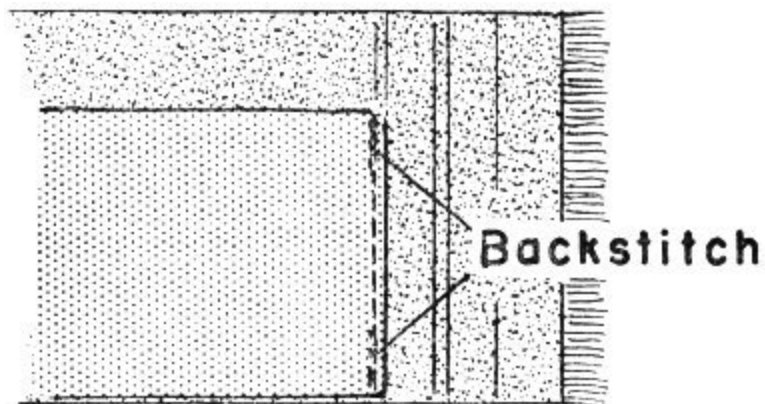
Readjust the regulator for backstitching, and hand turn the flywheel as you did on the other side of the seam, or if you do not have this regulator, again raise the presser foot very slightly and turn the flywheel 4 or 5 stitches to knot the thread.

Sew pockets into the washcloth

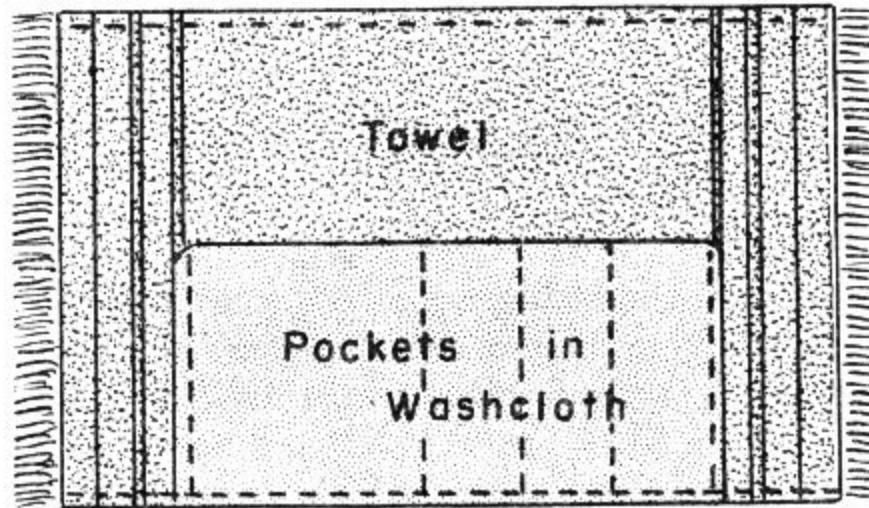
Fold the washcloth up onto the towel, hiding the seam which you just finished. Pin the washcloth in place, as shown in the illustration.



Stitch the side edges into place. If the hem on the washcloth is heavy, ask your leader to show you how to stitch just inside the hem to avoid bulk. If the hem is not heavy, stitch close to the edge by having the edge of the washcloth follow along the inside edge of the presser foot.



Pockets for the placemat or traveling kit are made by stitching the washcloth to the towel as shown in the illustration below.



To make the placemat, place a napkin, knife, fork, and spoon on the washcloth to give you an idea about the size of the pockets needed.

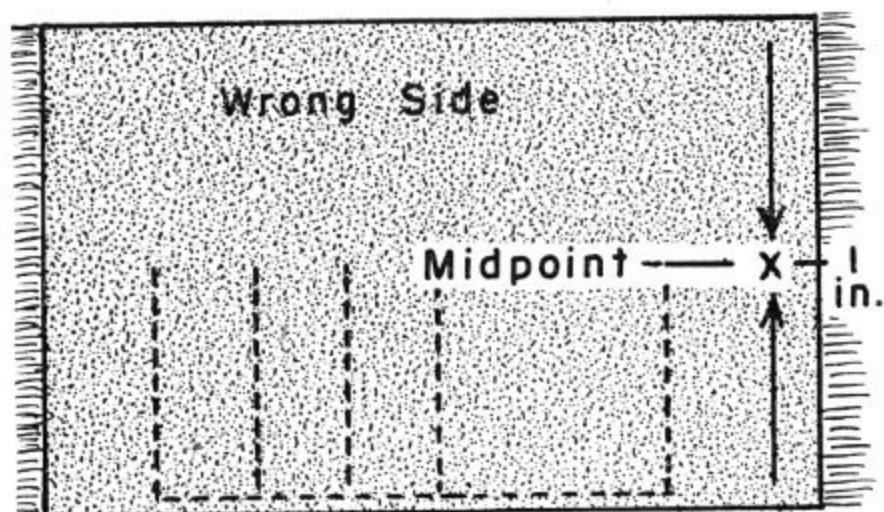
To make the traveling kit, choose the articles you would like to take and place them on the placemat.

Choose the stripes or checks nearest to the size pocket needed for each article; they will be your guide for stitching. Pin the washcloth to the towel along these stripes to make the pockets which you will stitch later. Slip the articles you want them to hold into the pockets to be sure you have left enough room for them. If everything slips into position easily, you are ready to sew. If not, the pockets can be made bigger by moving the pins to another stripe.

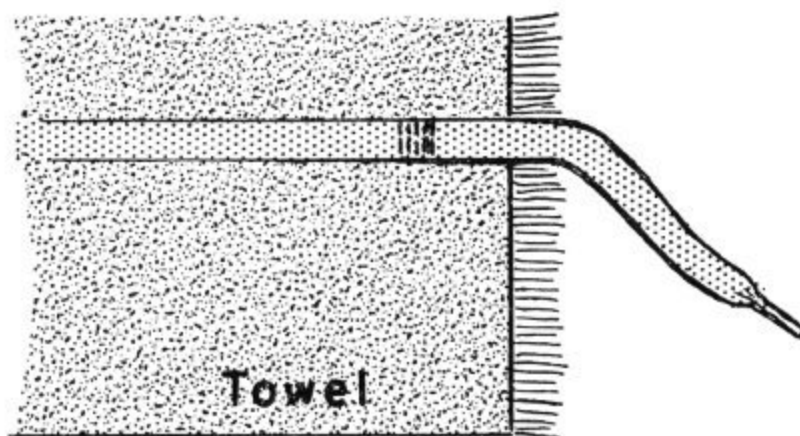
When you have decided which stripe you will use for each pocket, begin by backstitching at the lower seam and stitch up to the top of the washcloth. Backstitch again. One—two—three rows of stitching—and your pockets are finished!

Attach the tie to the towel

If the shoestring is very different in color from the towel, change the spool of thread to the color which matches the shoestring. Fold the shoestring in half. Pin the midpoint of the string to the towel at the point marked in the picture.

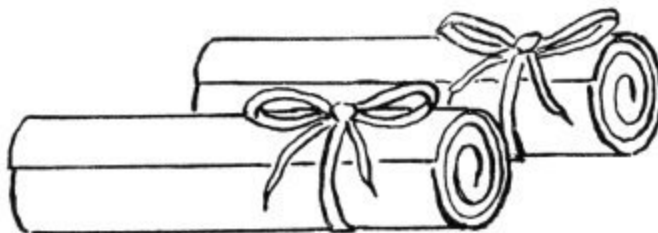


Fasten the string with very small stitches, by sewing back and forth across the width. Then clip threads close to the stitching line.



Finish your project

If you made a placemat insert a napkin, knife, fork, and spoon into the pockets. Or if you made a traveling kit, put your toilet articles or brushes in the pockets. Fold the upper edge down to cover the items. Then roll up the towel from the right to the left. Wrap the shoestring around it and tie it into a pretty bow. Your simple towel, washcloth, and shoestring have changed into *barbecue placemats* ... or a useful *traveling kit*!



Complete your record book

Your record book is important. Examine it carefully. As a first year member, you have just started to build a 4-H record. Each year your record book adds a new chapter to your 4-H club story. Are you proud of your record book?

Show others what you have learned

Displays

Invite your friends and neighbors to see what you have made. Be sure your articles are clean and well-pressed and that they look as nice as you can make them.

Demonstrations

A demonstration means “to show someone else how to do something.” Choose one special thing you have learned and use it for your demonstration.

Here are a few suggestions:

- How to use the shears to cut smooth, even edges
- How to use pins, a pincushion, and a thimble
- How to make a divided sewing box
- How to start, stop, and control the speed of the sewing machine
- How to guide material through the machine
- How to use the stitch regulator
- How to stitch straight (following a line or the presser foot)
- How to develop good sewing habits
- How to measure with a seam gauge or ruler
- How to press with a steam iron
- How to make a hem
- How to turn a corner during stitching
- How to match colors in materials and thread
- How to hand baste
- How to top-stitch

Are you ready for the next project?

- Have you learned the parts of the sewing machine and how to use them?
- Have you been careful of your personal grooming?
- Have you studied and improved your posture?
- Have you made two or more articles using the sewing machine?
- Have you kept your record book up to date?

24

THE 4-H CLUB PLEDGE

I pledge ...

my HEAD to clearer thinking
my HEART to greater loyalty
my HANDS to larger service
my HEALTH to better living
for my club, my community, and my country.

THE 4-H CLUB MOTTO

to make the best better

Cooperative Extension work in Agriculture and Home Economics, F. E. Price, director, Oregon State University and the United States Department of Agriculture cooperating. Printed and distributed in furtherance of Acts of Congress of May 8 and June 30, 1914.

20M—September 1961.

Transcriber's Notes

- Silently corrected a few typos.
- Retained publication information from the printed edition: this eBook is public-domain in the country of publication.
- In the text versions only, text in italics is delimited by _underscores_.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK IT'S FUN TO SEW
WITH A SEWING MACHINE ***

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